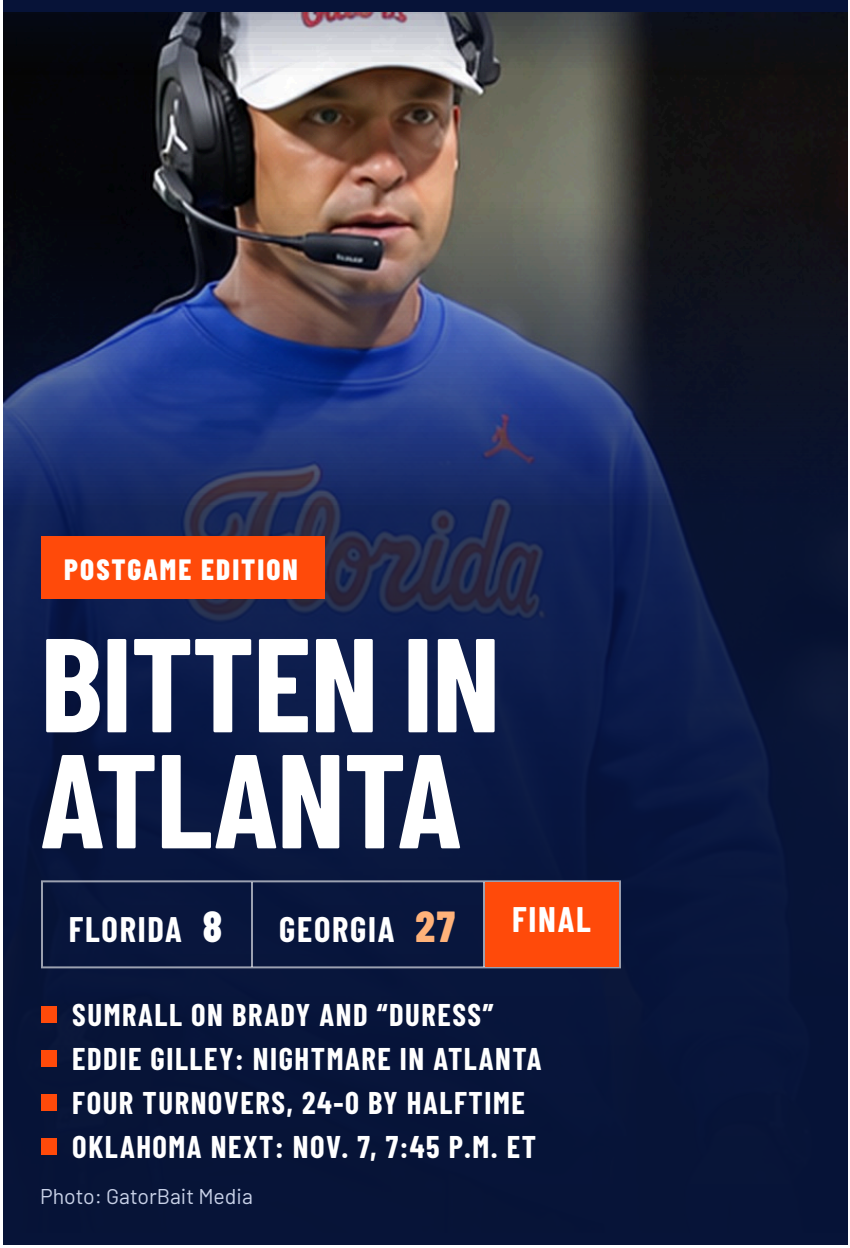
GATORBAIT
MAGAZINE

Saturday, October 31, 2026 · updated Monday, Nov. 2 · Week 9 · Florida vs. Georgia · Atlanta



POSTGAME EDITION

BITTEN IN ATLANTA

FLORIDA 8	GEORGIA 27	FINAL

- SUMRALL ON BRADY AND "DURESS"
- EDDIE GILLEY: NIGHTMARE IN ATLANTA
- FOUR TURNOVERS, 24-0 BY HALFTIME
- OKLAHOMA NEXT: NOV. 7, 7:45 P.M. ET

Photo: GatorBait Media

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FINAL

Florida	8	Georgia	27

Saturday, Oct. 31 · Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta · Florida 5-3, 3-3 SEC after the game (ESPN)

BY THE NUMBERS

Four turnovers and a run game that never started

Florida threw for 198 net yards to Georgia's 101, but turned the ball over four times and ran for 48 yards while Georgia ran for 217.

BOX SCORE

The full box score

	Florida	Georgia
First downs	15	19
Total yards	246	318
Passing	23/32, 198 yds	13/23, 101 yds
Rushing	28 for 48 yds	42 for 217 yds
Third down	4-12	6-15
Penalties	8 for 78 yds	4 for 32 yds
Turnovers	4	1
Possession	27:50	32:11

FLORIDA LEADERS

Passing Tramell Jones Jr.: 18/25, 172 YDS, 1 INT
Rushing Jadan Baugh: 17 CAR, 38 YDS
Receiving Bailey Stockton: 8 REC, 76 YDS

GEORGIA LEADERS

Passing Gunner Stockton: 13/23, 101 YDS
Rushing Nate Frazier: 12 CAR, 67 YDS, 1 TD
Receiving Craig Dandridge: 3 REC, 39 YDS

Team stats and leaders: ESPN box score (event 401856734).

POSTGAME · GATORBAIT STAFF

Gators Bitten in Atlanta: Four Turnovers Sink Florida in 27-8 Loss to No. 3 Georgia

By GatorBait Staff

ATLANTA - No. 3 Georgia beat Florida 27-8 on Saturday at Mercedes-Benz Stadium, turning three first-half Gators turnovers into a 24-0 halftime lead. Georgia's 66-yard sack-fumble return touchdown before the break and a 217-yard rushing night were more than a Florida offense could overcome. Florida, ranked No. 17, entered the game 5-2 overall and 3-2 in the SEC. Georgia entered 6-1 and 4-1.

Georgia took control before halftime

Georgia scored first on Nate Frazier's 1-yard run with 1:50 left in the opening quarter. P. Woodring added a 28-yard field goal with 8:55 left in the second quarter, and Bo Walker scored from 1 yard out with 1:55 left before the half.

The play that broke the game came with 29 seconds left in the half. Tramell Jones Jr. was sacked by Q. Johnson for a 3-yard loss, the ball came loose and Georgia returned it 66 yards for a touchdown. The Bulldogs led 24-0 at the break.

Florida answers late

Florida did not score until the fourth quarter. Jones ran 2 yards for a touchdown with 6:59 left, and Jadan Baugh threw to D. Wilson for the two-point conversion, cutting the deficit to 24-8. Woodring answered with a 21-yard field goal with 3:34 left to close the scoring.

The numbers that decided it

Florida's four turnovers were three interceptions and one lost fumble. Georgia turned the ball over once, on a lost fumble. Jones finished 18-of-25 for 172 yards with one interception, and Aaron Philo went 5-of-7 for 26 yards with two interceptions. Bailey Stockton caught eight passes for 76 yards.

Georgia ran 42 times for 217 yards, 5.2 per carry, with Frazier and Dwight Phillips Jr. each gaining 67 yards. Florida managed 54 rushing yards on 28 carries, 1.9 per attempt. Baugh carried 17 times for 38 yards.

Georgia finished with 318 total yards to Florida's 252. Gunner Stockton completed 13 of 23 passes for 101 yards for the Bulldogs. Georgia converted 6 of 15 third downs and Florida 4 of 12, and Florida was penalized eight times for 78 yards to Georgia's four for 32.

Next up: Oklahoma

Florida returns home to face Oklahoma at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium on Saturday, Nov. 7, at 7:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network.

More to come: full postgame analysis from Franz Beard and Buddy Martin.

COLUMN · EDDIE GILLEY

Nightmare in Atlanta

By Eddie Gilley

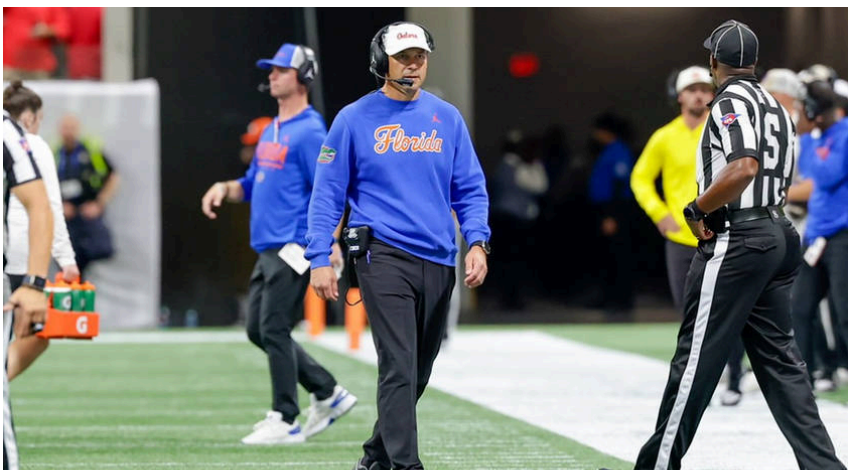


Photo: GatorBait Media.

Photo: GatorBait Media

Halloween was a nightmare for the Gators in Atlanta. Like the characters in the ad on TV, they chose to hide behind the chain saws in the barn rather than get in the running car. They just made dumb decisions all day long. That makes a good horror movie, but a terrible outcome for fans and players alike.

It started with a dumb decision to try to throw a ball out of bounds beyond the line of scrimmage by a falling Aaron Philo. He's the starter because he was less likely to make those kinds of decisions. Take the sack, punt the football. He knew it was stupid right after he did it. He probably wouldn't do it again in a million years. But the defense, which played pretty well despite the outcome, stood up and held the Georgia offense.

Then came the punt. Georgia lined up to punt and Florida went for the block. That was another dumb decision. Just let them punt the football to you. Instead, two Florida players hit the punter with enough force to

be called for roughing the punter. Georgia turned that mistake into a touchdown, and the game was changed for Gator fans.

Philo would make another mistake with a pass that was just a little too high for Eric Singleton Jr. Singleton could have caught it, but it went right through his hands into the waiting arms of a Georgia defender. That's been the nightmare for Gator fans during the six-year losing streak. Every possible bounce has gone the way of the Bulldogs. Three more points for the Bulldogs and more horror for the Gators.

Philo was replaced by Tramell Jones Jr., but the nightmares continued for Gator fans. Down 17-0 again late in a first half, the Gators tried to push to get a score before the half and hoping to score when they got the ball first in the second half like they did in Texas. Jones was hit as he was starting to throw and the ball came out and was ruled a fumble. Georgia scooped it up and rambled down the sideline all the way to the dooming touchdown. That's another aspect of the games over the last six years that keep Gator fans up at night. Points right before the half on turnovers by the Gators! 24-0 at the half and the only question was whether the Gators would score at all in Atlanta.

With all the horrors of the first half behind them, the Gators had a chance to make it a game, but Jones found a red shirt in the end zone to kill a promising drive. Jones would later score to prevent Kirby Smart from having the ultimate prize, ending Florida's 480 game streak of not being shut out. When the Bulldogs committed a penalty on fourth and goal to give the Gators a chance to score, Smart was seen face down on the turf in the dome. He wanted to be able to say that his team ended the streak the way Spurrier has said they scored 50 on the Dogs in Athens.

In the end, the Gators scored 8 positive points, and Georgia scored 10 positive points. However, the Gators gave the Dogs 17 points from turnovers. The Gators have no one to blame but themselves. The wounds were self-inflicted. The Bulldogs were the better team but only because the Gators gave them too much help. Another year of what could have been only leads to another year of Bulldog fans having the right to talk trash. It's just the third loss of the season, but this one will lead to a bit more nightmares for Gator fans.

COLUMN · FRANZ BEARD

For the UF offense, it was an October to forget

By Franz Beard



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Just as the clock struck midnight turning Cinderella's carriage into a pumpkin, the calendar turned a page on the Florida Gators. From a September to remember to an October they would rather forget, the Gators are no longer the media darlings they were when they hosed then 4th-ranked Ole Miss 52-28 on the final Saturday of September. From 4-0 and a No. 7 national ranking to 5-3, barely clinging to the last spot in the Associated Press top 25, the Gators nosedived their way through October, their only win a 27-24 shocker in Austin over Texas, which just two weeks before had been ranked No. 1 in the nation.

The month-to-month contrast is startling. In the four September wins, the Gators averaged 260 yards per game on the ground, averaging 5.87 yards per carry and scoring 18 touchdowns. Jadan Baugh, on everyone's Heisman Trophy list in September, ran for 600 yards and 11 touchdowns while averaging 7.22 yards per carry. Against Ole Miss, Baugh had 142 of Florida's 302 rushing yards and three touchdowns. His draft stock shot through the roof.

In the four games of October, Baugh ran for 201 yards and two touchdowns, went from Heisman candidate to a tough luck guy who every opposing defense targets, knowing the Florida offensive line can't

get him to the second level. Baugh had 201 yards on 69 carries for two touchdowns in the month of October. That is 2.91 per carry.

The running game that was so devastating in September accounted for only 364 yards on 137 carries, a dismal 2.65 yards per attempt. The Gators ran for three touchdowns in October.

In the four games of September, Aaron Philo averaged an astounding 10.5 yards per pass attempt while throwing for seven touchdowns. Injured against South Carolina, he missed the Texas game altogether and played only the first quarter-and-a-half against Georgia. He averaged 6.5 yards per pass attempt with two touchdowns and two picks in October.

The plunge in passing numbers for Philo and for Tramell Jones, who started the Texas game and finished the Georgia game, can be attributed to a couple of things. No Vernell Brown III has taken away Florida's most explosive player on the perimeter, not to mention his value as a punt returner capable of dramatically altering field position. Without the threat of Brown to stretch the field, opposing safeties have crowded the box, reducing the run threat.

Brown's impact cannot be under-estimated, but even if he had been healthy and on the field, someone would have had to block. Florida's offensive line has gone from the surprise of the SEC in September to the weak link it was predicted to be in all the preseason magazines and prognostications. False starts and holding calls have become routine occurrences. The Gators are dead last in the SEC in penalties (7.9 for 75 yards per game) and they rank No. 126 nationally. Not all the penalties can be laid at the feet of the O-line, but they are responsible for a rather hefty percentage of the flags.

In the first three games of October, only center Harrison Moore (74.4 percent against South Carolina) had a game that graded out better than 70 percent. In that South Carolina game, tackles Bryce Lovett (42.1 percent) and Emeka Ugorji (33.4 percent) were awful both in the run game and in pass protection. Ugorji gave up four QB pressures and two sacks.

Saturday against Georgia, the Gators allowed four sacks and 11 tackles for loss, but not all of those can be pinned against the O-line, which was overwhelmed by a high percentage of Georgia blitzes. Still, the run game produced only 48 yards on 28 carries (1.71 per attempt).

The Gators have four remaining games. At 5-3 (3-3 SEC), they are favored by a touchdown to beat Oklahoma Saturday. They will probably be underdogs at Kentucky and favored to beat both Vanderbilt and Florida State in the final two games. The potential is there for eight or even nine wins in the regular season, which would be a serious accomplishment for Jon Sumrall after last year's 4-8 record under Billy Napier.

But the Gators won't get to eight or nine wins without the offensive line rediscovering the success it had in September.

Associated Press top 25 (SEC teams bold face): 1. Miami 8-0; **2. Georgia 7-1;** 3. Utah 8-0; 4. Notre Dame 7-1; 5. UCLA 8-0; 6. Indiana 8-1; 7. BYU 7-1; **8. Kentucky 7-1; 9. Alabama 6-2; 10. Texas 6-2;** 11. Ohio State 6-2; **12. Ole Miss 6-2;** 13. Texas Tech 7-1; 14. Wake Forest 7-1; **15. LSU 6-2; 16. Tennessee 6-2;** 17. Houston 6-2; 18. Southern Cal 7-2; **19. Missouri 6-2;** 20. Boise State 7-1; 21. Iowa 6-2; 22. New Mexico 7-1; **23. South Carolina 5-3;** 24. Arizona 6-2; **25. FLORIDA 5-3**

AFCA Coaches top 25: 1. Miami 8-0; **2. Georgia 7-1;** 3. Indiana 8-1; 4. Utah 8-0; 5. UCLA 8-0; 6. Notre Dame 7-1; **7. Kentucky 7-1;** 8. BYU 7-1; **9. Alabama 6-2;** 10. Ohio State 6-2; **11. Texas 6-2; 12. Ole Miss 6-2;** 13. Texas Tech 7-1; 14. Wake Forest 7-1; **15. LSU 6-2; 16. Tennessee 6-2;** 17. Southern Cal 7-2; 18. Houston 6-2; **19. Missouri 6-2;** 20. Iowa 6-2; 21. Boise State 7-1; 22. Arizona 6-2; 23. Northwestern 6-2; 24. SMU 6-2; 25. New Mexico 7-1

AROUND THE SEC

No. 9 Alabama (6-2, 4-2 SEC): LSU is a playoff elimination game for Alabama. Lose and it's the 11th loss in three years for Kalen DeBoer and nobody on the planet needs a win in a big game more than he does. **Saturday: at No. 15 LSU (6-2, 3-2 SEC)**

Arkansas (3-5, 1-4 SEC): The Hogs ran for only 59 yards against Missouri. It was their third game of the season when they failed to reach at least 100 yards. **Saturday: at Auburn (4-4, 2-4 SEC), 12:45 p.m. SEC**

Network

Auburn (4-4, 2-4 SEC): The Tigers get somewhat of a break Saturday. They can't protect the passer (34 sacks allowed this year) and Arkansas can't rush the passer (just 10 sacks). **Saturday: Arkansas (3-5, 1-4 SEC), 12:45 p.m. SEC Network**

No. 2 Georgia (7-1, 5-1 SEC): The Bulldogs held Florida to 48 rushing yards and just 1.71 yards per carry. Georgia ranks ninth nationally against the run, allowing opponents just 86 yards per game and 2.72 yards per carry. **Saturday: at No. 12 Ole Miss (6-2, 4-2 SEC), 7:30 p.m., ABC**

No. 8 Kentucky (7-1, 5-1 SEC): The Wildcats moved up one spot in the AP poll to No. 8 nationally, which is their highest ranking since 2022 when they were No. 7 after four games. Prior to that, it was 1977 the last time the Wildcats secured such a high ranking. **Saturday: at No. 16 Tennessee (6-2, 3-2 SEC), 6:15 p.m., ESPN**

No. 15 LSU (6-2, 3-2 SEC): The Tigers have the No. 4 defense in the country (258.1 yards per game allowed). They rank seventh against the run and 13th against the pass. The Tigers have allowed only four touchdown passes all year. **Saturday: No. 9 Alabama (6-2, 4-2 SEC), 3:30 p.m., ABC**

Mississippi State (4-4, 2-4 SEC): The Bulldogs host Vanderbilt Saturday where they are likely to start AJ Swann at quarterback in place of injured Kamario Taylor. Swann's journey to Mississippi State has taken him from Vanderbilt (2022-23) to LSU (2024) and to Appalachian State (2025) prior to this season. **Saturday: vs. Vanderbilt (3-5, 0-5 SEC), 4:15 p.m. SEC Network**

No. 19 Missouri (6-2, 3-2 SEC): Jamal Roberts ran for 138 yards and a TD as Mizzou ran for 211 yards against Arkansas. Seeing his first action of the season after recovering from an offseason gunshot wound, Ahmad Hardy carried three times for 42 yards including a 37-yard run. **Saturday: No. 10 Texas (6-2, 3-2 SEC), 12 noon, ESPN**

Oklahoma (4-4, 2-3 SEC): The Sooners run for a little more than 106 yards per game and have only scored three touchdowns this season on the ground, which is dead last in Division I. The Sooners are 111th nationally in total offense (336.9 yards per game). **Saturday: at No. 25 FLORIDA (5-3, 3-3 SEC), 7:45 p.m. SEC Network**

No. 12 Ole Miss (6-2, 4-2 SEC): No Kewan Lacy, no problem. The Rebels still ran for 224 yards on Auburn with freshman Shekai Mills-Knight leading the way with 16 carries for 71 yards and a touchdown. Prior to Auburn, Mills-Knight had four carries for 42 yards. **Saturday: No. 2 Georgia (7-1, 5-1 SEC), 7:30 p.m., ABC**

No. 23 South Carolina (5-3, 3-3 SEC): The Gamecocks have won their last three games behind a red hot LaNorris Sellers. In the win over Oklahoma Saturday, Sellers threw for 301 yards and a TD plus ran for 96 yards and two scores. For the season he has thrown for 16 touchdowns and rushed for six more. **Saturday: Texas A&M (4-4, 1-4 SEC), 3 p.m., ESPN**

No. 16 Tennessee (6-2, 3-2 SEC): The Vols have yet to allow a team to gain more than 356 yards against their defense. They lead the nation with 35 sacks and they have an SEC best 66 tackles for loss. The Vols are 6.5-point favorites to take down Kentucky Saturday. **Saturday: No. 8 Kentucky (7-1, 5-1 SEC), 6:15 p.m., ESPN**

No. 10 Texas (6-2, 3-2 SEC): The Longhorns are a surprising 3.5-point favorite for Saturday's game at Missouri where the Tigers are 23-3 in the last four years. **Saturday: at No. 19 Missouri (6-2, 3-2 SEC), 12 noon, ESPN**

Texas A&M (4-4, 1-4 SEC): The Aggies defensive struggles can be traced to their lack of a pass rush. The Aggies have eight sacks all year, dead last in Division I. Despite their inability to rush quarterbacks, Texas A&M ranks 30th nationally in total defense (315 yards per game). **Saturday: at No. 23 South Carolina (5-3, 3-3 SEC), 3 p.m., ESPN**

Vanderbilt (3-5, 0-5 SEC): The Commodores are dead last in the SEC and No. 130 nationally in turnover margin. They coughed up the football 14 times and have forced seven turnovers. **Saturday: at Mississippi State (4-4, 2-4 SEC), 4:15 p.m. SEC Network**

COUNTDOWN TO FIRING DAY: NOVEMBER 2, EDITION

EXTINCT SPECIES LIST

Mike Norvell, Florida State: Seminole faithful will be organizing car washes and bake sales to contribute to the estimated $47 million hard cash needed to fire Norvell. Also, it will take a few million more to buy

out the assistants and staffers. The cost of hiring a new coach points to one person and one person only — Jimbo Fisher. He won the 2013 national championship coaching the Seminoles, requires no buyout or moving costs since he already lives in Tallahassee, and because Texas A&M paid him $77 million to go away he will work cheap. FSU will talk big names, but in the end it's going to be Jimbo. Rick Stockstill, a former FSU QB and head coach at Middle Tennessee State, will be the interim.

Dave Aranda, Baylor: The Bears were so distraught over the firing of Aranda that they played their best game of the season in whomping UCF at the Bounce House. Jeff Traylor (UT-San Antonio), Willie Fritz (Houston), Jason Eck (New Mexico) and Shannon Dawson (Miami OC) should emerge as the top candidates. Smart money is on Traylor.

Dave Doeren, North Carolina State: The deal to hire Philip Rivers is all but done. It helps that his son is a stud high school QB already committed to the Wolfpack.

Mike Locksley, Maryland: Brian Kelly wants the job. He would bring instant credibility and he is the highest profile coach currently available.

Phil Longo, Sam Houston: Quick trigger. He was 3-17 in his second season but he inherited a mess at a school seriously lacking resources.

ON LIFE SUPPORT

Greg Schiano, Rutgers: He almost beat Michigan but probably won't win another game. If he stays it's because they can't cover the $20 million buyout.

Deion Sanders, Colorado: The Buffs shocked K-State Saturday. That win and a $26 million buyout probably keep him around another year.

Joe Moorhead, Akron: The Zips are 1-7 and there isn't a winnable game in the last four. If he survives it's because they have no money.

Kyle Whittingham, Michigan: The new AD didn't hire Whittingham and could succumb to boosters who want a higher profile coach. The buyout is $25 million but money is no object for Michigan.

ENDANGERED SPECIES LIST

Steve Sarkisian, Texas: The Longhorns are 6-2 and need to make the College Football Playoff. They have the talent to do it, but do they have the head coaching? His buyout is more than $50 million, a day's interest for some of the oil gozillionaire boosters.

Brent Venables, Oklahoma: He got a six-year contract extension earlier in the year. Now they're unhappy about it. The buyout is nearly $52 million but that isn't an issue. What may save him is he's a Bob Stoops legacy. He probably gets one more year unless the Sooners go totally in the tank.

Kalen DeBoer, Alabama: A loss to LSU this weekend seems likely. Is that enough to fire him? AD Greg Byrne will be under extreme pressure if Bama misses the playoff. He already has 10 losses in three years. Nick never did that.

Tony Elliott, Virginia: Winning 11 games last year buys him another year, but his seat will be very hot.

Tim Albin, Charlotte: Google him. He's won everywhere he's ever been. That doesn't explain 2-18 in his first two seasons as Charlotte's head ball coach. They have no money and they play in a 15,000-seat stadium.

Pat Narduzzi, Pittsburgh: He's 85-64 and gets the Panthers December vacations to such exotic locales as Detroit for bowl games. How long before the luster of that 2021 ACC championship wears off?

Bill O'Brien, Boston College: He's a surprising 4-4 this year. No one expected that. If he's smart he gets another job. BC is a dead end.

COLUMN · FRANZ BEARD

Florida basketball: Gators start season with sky high expectations

By Franz Beard



Photo: GatorBait Media.

There is this old Southern saying that goes like this: "If you shoot low, you'll probably hit your target." There is no shooting low for Florida's preseason No. 1 basketball team, who open their pursuit of a second national championship in three years tonight at Tampa's Benchmark Arena (6 p.m., ESPN2) against No. 14 Miami. The Gators return the nation's most experienced starting lineup, led by Tommy Haugh, Rueben Chinyelu and Alex Condon, all of whom chose to return to Florida for one more chance at a title rather than move on to the NBA.

The starting lineup, which includes Denzel Aberdeen, back to UF after a year in exile at Kentucky, and Boogie Fland, who started all 35 games at the point for the Gators last year, has a combined 502 games of playing experience, 291 in the starting lineup. Haugh was a second team All-America last year and is projected as the SEC Player of the Year. Chinyelu was the winner of the Naismith National Defensive Player of the Year last season. Condon is a two-time All-SEC performer.

"It's national championship or bust for this team," Haugh said during the summer months. "That's my mindset. I think that's our whole team's mindset."

If there are concerns for Todd Golden, they center around two things: 3-point shooting and the bench.

In exhibition games against North Florida, Baylor and Stetson, the Gators were a combined 27-99 from the 3-point line. After a dismal 4-29 effort against Baylor in the second exhibition game, Aberdeen and last

year's SEC Sixth Man of the Year Urban Klavzar heated up to combine for 10 threes in 17 attempts. The rest of the team went 1-10.

History says the Gators should be better this year. Aberdeen, who averaged 13.5 per game last year at Kentucky, is a career 35.1 percent shooter from three, while Klavzar shot 40.6 percent last year off the bench. Haugh slumped to 32.6 percent as the season wore on a year ago, but he proved in the Gators' run to the NCAA title in 2025 that he can hit threes in the clutch. AJ Brown, who redshirted last year after transferring from Ohio, is a career 37.1 percent shooter from three and international import Domen Petrovic shot 36.3 percent in the Slovenian league.

The bench didn't exactly rip and shred during the preseason. Against Baylor bench production was limited to three points. Klavzar started and scored 24 against Stetson, which is why bench production was a mere four points. Florida's bench rotation figures to be Klavzar and Isaiah Brown first off the bench on the perimeter, and Petrovic and Arturas Butajevas in the big man rotation. AJ Brown played well against North Florida, didn't shoot well against Baylor and didn't play against Stetson. CJ Ingram, expected to be a consistent contributor, has been sidelined with lower back issues, and Alex Lloyd has yet to get his shot working.

Last Thursday Golden said, "Our reserves didn't give us as big of a lift as we need [against Stetson] and that's going to be something that we need some guys to step up before you know Monday and as the season starts.

If there is a key to the bench rotation, it could be Isaiah Brown, who provided explosive minutes at both ends of the court last season. Brown had a pair of lackluster performances against Baylor and Stetson.

"I think that's kind of the challenge is figuring out how to get guys comfortable, playing unafraid to fail and just kind of letting it all hang out a little bit," Golden said last week. "And we got to find that. We've had a really good camp ... I think Isaiah is the one that we're kind of talking about a lot because he's proven it before, and we still have full confidence that he'll get ripping. And for him, I think it's a matter of time."

In Miami, the Gators will be facing an experienced team that won 26 games a year ago in Jai Lucas' first year as head coach. Lucas, the son of former Maryland All-American John Lucas, spent his freshman year playing for the Gators back in 2007-08 before transferring to Texas. His already deep roster was bolstered in the offseason by picking up shot blocker Somto Cyril from Georgia and point guard Brent Bland from Saint Peter's.

Golden knows what to expect from the Hurricanes, who went 26-9 a year ago when they beat Missouri and then lost to Purdue in the second round of the NCAA Tournament. Key players back from that team are Malik Reneau (18.9 points, 6.9 rebounds) and Shelton Henderson (13.9 points, 4.9 rebounds). Reneau has had some injury issues in the preseason but is expected to play limited minutes against the Gators.

"They have a lot of talent across the board," Golden said. "They're pretty big, and they picked up some good pieces. I think they have a little more depth than they had last year."

STARTING LINEUPS

No. 1 Florida: Alex Condon (6-11, 236, SR); Rueben Chinyelu (6-10, 265, SR); Tommy Haugh (6-9, 215, SR); Denzel Aberdeen (6-5, 190, 5th); Boogie Fland (6-3, 185, JR)

No. 14 Miami: Shelton Henderson (6-6, 239, SO); Somto Cyril (6-11, 263, JR); Caleb Gaskins (6-8, 221, FR); Dante Allen (6-4, 225, SO); Acaden Lewis (6-2, 187, SO)

AS THE NCAA TURNS ... SEASON STARTS, LAWSUITS GALORE

The Division I college basketball season begins in earnest today, but not without eligibility issues being fought in courts across the country as the NCAA, in its infinite wisdom, chooses to challenge athletes who graduated high school in 2022 from gaining a fifth year of eligibility. The NCAA contends that granting a fifth year to athletes who were fourth-year seniors during the 2025-26 athletic year while granting a fifth year to all of last year's underclassmen gives unfair advantages and undermines its ability to enforce its own rules. Last week in Kentucky and Ohio, the NCAA took a 1-2 punch to the chin from the Kentucky Court of Appeals and the Ohio Supreme Court.

In Kentucky, Court of Appeals Judge Sara Walter Combs denied the NCAA's request for emergency relief from a temporary injunction that granted more than 30 athletes eligibility. In Ohio, where Governor Mike DeWine issued an executive order on October 13 that granted a fifth year of eligibility to all athletes in the state of Ohio who graduated in 2022, the Ohio Supreme Court intervened, upholding a preliminary injunction from a court in Cincinnati that gave a fifth year to a group of athletes, mostly from Xavier and Cincinnati.

Judge Combs wrote in her decision that the NCAA failed to prove "imminent, ruinous and incalculable injury" by granting the fifth year. Further, Judge Combs wrote that the NCAA continues to "flip-flop repeatedly as our courts work through the underlying issues."

In Ohio, where a group of athletes mostly from Xavier and Cincinnati, won a temporary restraining order against the NCAA during the summer, Governor DeWine issued an executive order stating that athletes from the 2022 high school class should be allowed to play providing, of course, they are under the NCAA age limit and have not participated in professional league activities. The Ohio Supreme Court cited the executive order in its decision to allow the preliminary injunction to remain in effect.

On both rulings, the NCAA stated it will appeal in the Federal Courts. An NCAA legal beagle in Ohio said, "The NCAA will continue to pursue all available avenues to defend the membership's rules." In addition to continuing its fight in the courts against the athletes, the NCAA decided to sue the governor of Ohio, claiming his executive order "has no foundation."

Meanwhile, on Wednesday in the state of Georgia, RJ Godfrey, who played at Clemson but is seeking a fifth year to play at Arizona, and 14 other players withdrew their names from a lawsuit against the NCAA. Godfrey was initially granted a temporary restraining order in his home state of Georgia, but the Georgia Court of Appeals issued a stay on September 9. With oral arguments now scheduled for January 12, Godfrey and others involved in his lawsuit withdrew their names, presumably to seek other pathways toward eligibility.

Responding to a question regarding the NCAA's decision to fight to the bitter end in the courts, where historically it loses, Tennessee basketball coach Rick Barnes took a measured shot against the NCAA.

"You know what I wish somebody would do right now?" Barnes asked. "I wish they would do an audit of how much money the NCAA is spending on attorney fees. I'd like them to do that because they've dug their heels in. If you think about this right now, I think there are like maybe 500 cases of guys and girls that are trying to play. What if each one of them sued the NCAA for a million dollars? Think about it. It's $500 million. [The NCAA is] going to have to go to court with them. I'd rather they take that money and give it to Olympic sports, you know? And my deal is, whether it is what it is, [the NCAA] created this problem, which they have in the past, too."

Here are SEC players currently involved in NCAA lawsuits:

Auburn: Kolby King eligible

FLORIDA: Denzel Aberdeen eligible

LSU: Donovan Dent and Skyy Clark eligible

Mississippi State: Kimani Hamilton eligible

Missouri: Mark Mitchell eligible; CJ Gunn ineligible

Oklahoma: Duke Brennan and BJ Edwards eligible; Tae Davis ineligible

Ole Miss: Micah Handlogten and Corey Stephenson eligible

Tennessee: Jalen Washington ineligible

Texas A&M: Jordan Pope eligible; Rylan Griffen ineligible

THIS WEEK IN THE SEC

Monday games

Sam Houston at No. 20 Alabama

Arkansas-Pine Bluff at No. 12 Arkansas

North Carolina Central at Georgia

Tennessee Tech at Mississippi State

East Texas A&M at Oklahoma

Alcorn State at Ole Miss

Chicago State at No. 7 Texas

Bellarmine at No. 24 Vanderbilt

Tuesday games

Manhattan at No. 23 Kentucky

LSU-New Orleans at LSU

Cleveland State at Missouri

Stetson at South Carolina

Wofford at No. 8 Tennessee

Alabama State at Texas A&M

Wednesday game

Southeastern Louisiana at Auburn

COLUMN · BUDDY MARTIN

Take a Deep Breath. It's Basketball Season.

By Buddy Martin

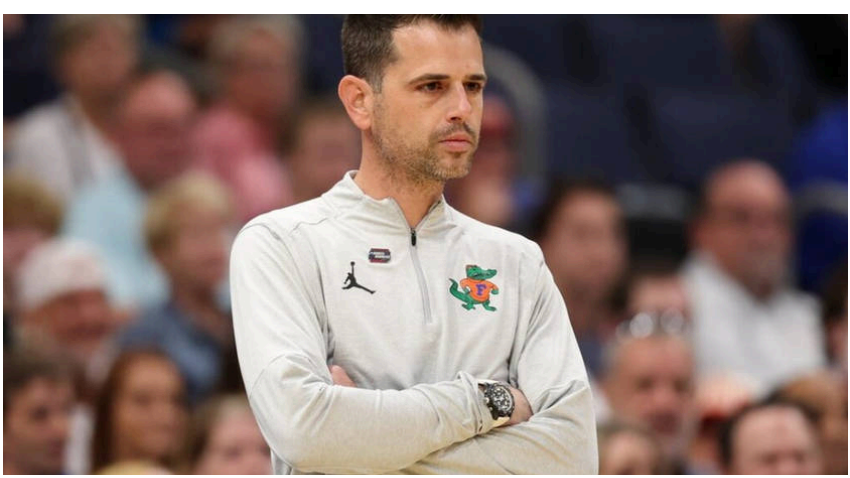


Photo: GatorBait Media.

By Buddy Martin

"Well, we're a basketball school anyway."

November has arrived, which means Gator fans can inventory the bruises from Georgia, check what's left of their football optimism — even though they remained 25th in today's latest AP poll — and reach for that dependable old crutch:

"Well, we're a basketball school anyway."

There. Feel better?

Don't put the blood-pressure cuff away just yet.

Todd Golden's team begins the real basketball season tomorrow night with a No. 1 ranking and considerably higher expectations than normal.

The Gators are supposed to be the distraction. Not another reason to lie awake staring at the ceiling.

So as football rivals Miami and Georgia enjoy the rarified air of #1 and #2, and the Gators are looking up at #8 Kentucky, #9 Alabama and #10 Texas, there are going to be more gridiron opportunities ahead as we see how long Florida can hold serve on the preordained top spot in hoops.

As Jackie Gleason used to say, "How sweet it is!"

Although Gleason probably hadn't just watched his guards go a combined 0-for-17 from the three-point line.

That'll take some sugar out of your coffee.

A Crutch With Championship Expectations

I've always appreciated a good fallback when I get a hitch in my get-along. For older Gators who have wandered through a few of football's darker neighborhoods, basketball offers something better than a flashlight.

It offers a reason to turn on the television without first establishing an escape route.

Starting the season ranked No. 1 in America is a pretty comfortable holding pattern. This isn't waiting for a studio apartment in the low-rent district. This is complaining because the penthouse elevator takes too long.

Still, Florida fans are entitled to enjoy the accommodations.

My grandmother would have said, "Don't look a gift horse in the mouth."

I never understood why we were inspecting the horse in the first place. In today's college sports, I'd check whether he had an agent.

The point, presumably, is gratitude.

And there is plenty to appreciate about Golden's program.

There is also a small matter to address before we turn November into a four-month victory parade.

The basketball hasn't been particularly pretty.

Exhibition Is Not an Alibi

Yes, I know. Exhibition games.

They don't count.

Neither does a practice swing, but if you take out the beverage cart, somebody ought to mention it.

Florida's first two exhibitions included poor shooting, uneven bench play and stretches when the effort didn't look worthy of the number beside the school's name.

Stetson led the Gators 42–40 at halftime.

No disrespect to Donnie Jones or Stetson, but the nation's top-ranked team should not need a halftime reminder that rebounds are available to both clubs.

Against Baylor, Florida lost 82–76 in overtime. The three-point shooting was the sort of thing you normally watch through your fingers.

Denzel Aberdeen went 0-for-10 from deep. Urban Klavzar went 0-for-7.

Together: 0-for-17.

That isn't a cold spell. That's a missing-person report for the jump shot.

Aberdeen finished 3-for-17 overall. Boogie Fland tried to keep the offense moving, but when nobody believes the next perimeter shot is going in, the floor gets crowded in a hurry.

Suddenly, all that lovely frontcourt talent is working in a broom closet.

Tomorrow night against Miami in Tampa, the exhibition excuse expires.

They start keeping the receipts.

The Big Men Need Some Help

The good news is that Florida's foundation remains substantial enough to require its own building permit.

Rueben Chinyelu. Thomas Haugh. Alex Condon.

That is a frontcourt worth getting excited about.

Chinyelu brings the muscle and rim protection, along with a personality that apparently doesn't require him to scowl through the entire day to prove he's tough.

Haugh plays as though every loose ball has personally offended him.

Condon supplies the Australian grit and the passing touch of a big man who understands that an assist is not an admission of weakness.

They give Florida size, skill, toughness and familiarity.

What they cannot give Florida is a permanent exemption from making outside shots.

At some point, somebody has to loosen the lid on the basket.

A No. 1 ranking is an honor. It is not a six-point lead at tipoff, and Miami is unlikely to stand around admiring the stationery.

Golden doesn't need a masterpiece in the opener.

He does need a team that rebounds, competes and looks connected when the shots refuse to fall.

The standard, to borrow a word currently getting plenty of exercise around Gainesville, should travel from one end of the floor to the other.

Meanwhile, back to football, Jon Sumrall says things will improve.

"This is not our standard."

Good. Hold him to it.

Gator fans have heard enough promises to qualify for continuing education credits in disappointment.

After the Billy years, another "check's in the mail" speech isn't going to buy much patience.

Sumrall deserves the opportunity to make his words mean something. The remaining schedule will provide ample supervision:

• Oklahoma, Nov. 7, at home.

• Kentucky, Nov. 14, in Lexington.

• Vanderbilt, Nov. 21, at home.

• Florida State, Nov. 27, in Tallahassee.

There is still football to play. I can see a 7-5 in there. Still something to salvage. A bowl bid may not be the destination anybody circled in August, but it beats spending December explaining the rebuilding process to the furniture.

Eventually, perhaps Florida won't need one sport to administer first aid for the other.

For now, I'm grateful basketball is here.

I'm grateful for Golden, those big men and the possibility of watching a Florida team meet enormous expectations instead of explaining why expectations were unreasonable.

So take a deep breath, Gator fans. Just don't hold it until the next three-pointer goes in.

COLUMN · FRANZ BEARD

Autopsy Cause of Gators Defeat: Self-Inflicted Wounds

By Franz Beard



Photo: GatorBait Media.

Photo: GatorBait Media

Watching the film of Florida's 27-8 loss to Georgia will be the equivalent of performing an autopsy for Jon Sumrall. Cause of death – in this case defeat – will read "self-inflicted wounds."

The Georgia Bulldogs are a fine football team. Nothing they did Saturday would lead someone to believe the Bulldogs (7-1, 5-1 SEC) aren't deserving of the nation's No. 3 ranking. They are big, strong, physical on both lines of scrimmage and perhaps the most fundamentally sound team in the country. On the offensive and defensive lines, the Bulldogs looked like grown men going against Florida's boys.

Make no mistake about it, Georgia is very, very good, perhaps good enough to win a third national championship in the last six years, but it took complicity on the part of the 17th-ranked Gators (5-3, 3-3 SEC) for the Bulldogs to pull even with 8th-ranked Kentucky (7-1, 5-1 SEC) at the top of the Southeastern Conference standings. Of Georgia's 27 points, 24 were a direct result of Florida mistakes.

"They didn't need our help tonight, but we gave it to them," Sumrall said. "And they won the game, but the Gators didn't help the Gators enough tonight."

If it wasn't turnovers – the Gators threw three interceptions and lost a fumble that was returned 66 yards for a touchdown – it was penalties. There were eight of them, five in the first half when the Gators were smoked, 24-0.

Here is a breakdown of the first half carnage:

FLORIDA'S FIRST POSSESSION

Taking over after Georgia's Peyton Woodring missed a 43-yard field goal, the Gators moved 13 yards in two plays, gaining the first down on a 10-yard Aaron Philo to Lacota Dippre pass. Philo and freshman Justin Williams collaborated on what would have been a 17-yard pass that moved the ball to the Georgia 45, but Dallas Wilson was called for a hold, moving the ball back to the UF 32. On third down, Philo was chased out of the pocket and rather than take a sack, he tried to underhand the ball in the direction of a receiver only to have Georgia's Ellis Robinson pick it off.

"I tell our quarterbacks all the time, I want every drive to end in some sort of kick, and a punt is one of those that I can live with," Sumrall said. "We just kind of gave them a gift there."

CRITICAL ROUGHING THE KICKER PENALTY

The Florida defense responded to the turnover by forcing Georgia to punt on fourth-and-15 from the UF 46. The Gators tried to block the punt, but Jaden Edgecombe missed the ball as he dived, hitting Miller below the knees. Given new life, Georgia needed five plays to put the ball in the end zone for a 7-0 lead with 1:50 remaining in the first quarter.

"We liked the block we had called," Sumrall said. "We don't leave our feet to block the punt. We want to hand block it in that situation ... critical mistake. That was a turning point from a momentum standpoint in the game, because our defense had gotten a stop after the pick and then to gift them a new set of downs gave them life. You can't do that against anybody in sleep, much less a team like that."

FLORIDA'S FIRST POSSESSION OF THE SECOND QUARTER

On third-and-1 at the UF 28, Bryce Lovett was flagged for a false start. Philo and Amir Jackson connected on a 10-yard pass for a first down at the 33. Philo hit Eric Singleton Jr. in the hands with what would have been at least a 20-yard gain but the ball went through the wickets and into the hands of Georgia's Demello Jones, who ran the ball back to the Florida 32. An unsportsmanlike penalty was tagged on the end of the

play. That one was on Sumrall, who got in the way of one of the referees. The Florida defense forced a 28-yard Woodring field goal. Georgia 10, Florida 0.

GEORGIA'S NEXT POSSESSION: SECOND QUARTER

Taking over on their own 19, Georgia drove to the UF 41 where, on second and 10, Gunner Stockton threw wide right and incomplete at the UF 35. As Talyn Taylor broke for the sideline, Cormani McClain got his hand caught up in Taylor's facemask. The ensuing 15-yard penalty gave Georgia a first down at the UF 26. Four plays later, the Bulldogs punched it in for a 17-0 lead with 1:55 left in the half.

SACK, FUMBLE, SCORE

Tramell Jones Jr., who had taken over at QB for Philo after the second interception, completed passes of 17 yards to Amir Jackson, 14 yards to Dallas Wilson and five yards to Bailey Stockton, moving the ball to the Georgia 37, well within Patrick Durkin's field goal range. On second-and-5, Georgia's Quintavius hit Jones from behind before he got into his throwing motion. The ball landed at the 34 where Chris Cole picked it up, got a convoy down the sideline and ran it in for a 66-yard defensive TD. A 17-3 deficit had seemed certain, but now the Gators were behind 24-0. Seventeen points on turnovers and another seven aided by a 15-yard penalty.

SECOND HALF: A PICK IN THE END ZONE AND A STREAK PRESERVED

After a first half in which the Gators managed only 109 yards, Jones got the offense somewhat ignited on Florida's first possession of the third quarter, but Singleton couldn't come down with a third down pass at the Georgia 28.

Florida's second possession of the half avoided disaster when Georgia was flagged for roughing the passer, nullifying an interception by Demello Jones. Two plays later, Jones and Singleton connected for 18 yards. A 7-yard run by Jadan Baugh and a 10-yard scramble by Jones made it first and goal at the Georgia three. On second and goal, Jones rolled left and threw an interception on a pass intended for Singleton. Had Jones looked slightly to his right he would have seen Baugh open at the goal line.

Georgia managed only 14 yards of offense in the third quarter, but started moving the ball in the fourth quarter, taking it all the way down to the UF 11. On first down, Stockton flipped the ball to Talyn Taylor, who lost the ball when he was hit by DJ Coleman. Myles Graham emerged from a pack of Gators with the football, returning it 42 yards to the Georgia 48.

It took nine plays following Graham's sprint down the sideline to ensure the Gators would add to their NCAA record streak of 480 games without being shut out, but it wouldn't have happened without a fourth-and-goal pass interference call against Georgia. On the next play, Tramell Jones dived in from two yards out for Florida's only touchdown with 6:59 remaining in the game. The Gators cut the Georgia lead to 24-8 when Jadan Baugh tossed a two-point conversion pass to Dallas Wilson.

THE O-LINE HAD A BAD DAY AT THE OFFICE

Georgia finished the game with four sacks good for -19 yards. There were seven other tackles for loss. Eleven negative plays, three picks and a fumble are a recipe for disaster in the SEC, particularly against a team like Georgia. The Bulldogs keyed their entire defense on Jadan Baugh, holding him to 38 yards on 17 carries. Throwing lanes and clean pockets were a rarity for both Philo and Jones. Neither quarterback played well enough for the Gators to win the game, but they didn't get a lot of help, either, particularly from the O-line.

"I felt bad for both quarterbacks at times ... I don't know that either one of them independently played good enough for us to win the game, but I also don't know that it's really fully fair to evaluate either one of them fully because I don't think there was enough help around them," Sumrall said. "Not just the offensive line. We had receivers misaligned today, not run the right route, or run the wrong route a handful of times. The timing on things were off. I didn't think we played up front good enough, though, on the offensive line to help them. And we knew coming into this game we needed to stay ahead of the chains and give ourselves an opportunity."

THE DECISION TO START PHILO

Philo missed the Texas game with a shoulder injury suffered against South Carolina. Jones got hurt in the win over Texas. After the bye week prior to Georgia, Philo had better practice days on Tuesday and

Wednesday, earning the start.

"Tramell, really, on Thursday in the bye week, our last practice, was not anywhere near 100 percent," Sumrall said. "He was – I'm not gonna disclose his injury – but he could not come out of the run action, play-action plays full speed with the injury he had. It presented worse later in the bye week. Then on the Monday practice, just from an execution standpoint, Philo was a lot clearer earlier in the week, Monday, Tuesday. Tramell really didn't look great with his health.

"I'm not gonna tell you all his injury, because I'm not trying to help other people right now, but he's got a real injury. Like, I think some people are probably questioning what's going on. He's got an injury that may require surgery after the year, but he didn't look really good until Wednesday, honestly. Philo looked better this past week, the entire week. We talked through, as a staff, after the first three days of practice, how they looked. We talked every day about it, but through three days, Philo was executing better on Monday, Tuesday, so we shifted to getting Philo the majority of the one reps on Wednesday was when it was kind of like, that was the direction we're probably going here. I let both of them know on Friday, and then we just worked through as a staff. I said, hey, look, here's the situations where we would make a change after a few drives. It'd either be (A) Philo's not playing great or (B) really the other one is. He could be playing fine, but we just felt like we needed a spark or something different. Philo's first interception was clearly on him, bad decision with the football. The second one hit the receiver in the hands, so we gotta catch that football, but I just felt like, hey, let's give Tramell a shot. He got probably almost fifty-fifty reps total in the week, Tramell did, just maybe not as many with the ones, they got about the same number of reps if you did a pitch count, because what we do in practice is we usually give the ones a block of plays and the twos and get the same exact block of plays. So preparation on knowing what to do really doesn't change."

TOO MANY SELF-INFLICTED WOUNDS

In the end, this came down to the Gators giving the game away. Georgia owed its 24 first half points to Florida mistakes. Had the Gators played the first half as well as they did the second, it would have been a

competitive game, but you can't win in the SEC with four turnovers, four sacks allowed and no running game.

"It's the self-inflicted ones, the things that we do that are reckless, that hurt ourselves, that I really highlight, and that'll get, all that stuff gets shown on Monday in our team meeting," Sumrall said. "We have a penalty report tape. We show the ones that are egregious or self-inflicted that are not football plays that I have a problem with, or that are maybe alignment mistakes. And we have to clean that up. We got to play better football."

A HEAD COACH APOLOGY TO THE FANS

"I apologize to our fans," Sumrall said. "What the Florida Gators standard is – and do not shy away from the fact that we have to be a lot better across the board – it starts with me as the head football coach here. I have to have our guys more ready, more ready to play and more prepared. I'm grateful for our fan turnout, grateful for our fanbase. They should be pissed off. I hope they are. I am too, and we're gonna get this right ... I promise you we're gonna get this right. I commit to giving everything I have for us to freaking get this right, and I'm freaking not okay with today, I'm not gonna whine and complain. We gotta get better. I'm so sick over it ... Everybody's pissed off and should be."

COLUMN · LOREN MEADOWS

Postgame Analysis: Florida Gators (5-3, 3-3) v. Georgia Bulldogs (7-1, 5-1)

By Loren Meadows



Photo: GatorBait Media.

Photo: GatorBait Media

Florida needs to make Georgia earn wins in the series, not give it away as turnovers, penalties and poor execution doom the Gators in the Atlanta Gridiron Classic.

What We Thought: As much as Florida seemed prepared to come to Atlanta and possibly pull an upset the health of their football team in particular with both quarterbacks was uncertain. Wednesday both quarterbacks were listed as questionable on the availability report along with Vernell Brown who has missed the last three games with a lower body injury.

Things just didn't seem to be aligned for the Gators to be less sucky and get it done. Defensively Georgia boasted one of the best linebacker units in the country and a defensive line that despite start power just did their job so those same linebackers seemed to live in the backfield.

Offensively Gunner Stockton had played fairly well leading the SEC in pass efficiency and the threat of multiple weapons in the backfield and perimeter combined with Stockton's legs would be a major concern for the Gator defense.

The Georgia offense had found a way to simply not beat itself and allow a dominant defense to create opportunities for a short field off of turnovers.

Florida would try to take an improving defense and look to recreate the five sacks at the expense of Texas and make life difficult for Stockton. The effort would be there but Florida still looked to be about a year away from having a roster that can get to Georgia without a little luck.

What We Got: Since 2021 this game was about mistakes and missed opportunities for the Gators. Jon Sumrall took full responsibility for the number of mistakes and mishaps of Saturday's game but this is literally a trend that has to stop. Saturday after a great defensive stop, Aaron Philo made a dreadful mistake, irresponsibly throwing the ball up for grabs for an interception by Ellis Robinson IV. This would begin a day that saw the Florida defense surrender just 318 yards but where the Bulldogs would score 17 points off turnovers.

Tramell Jones would enter the game in relief of Philo but was average at best going 18 of 25 for 172 yards with one INT. As stated earlier, for five straight years the Gators have brought many of these mistakes on themselves as they have dropped interceptions, made costly penalties, tipped catchable balls and found a way to not capitalize against the more talented Bulldogs.

The second interception for Philo occurred on a solid ball that went through the hands of Eric Singleton Jr. for an interception. Later in the game Singleton would drop a fade route from Jones on a desperately needed third down when Florida was still in the game.

"Our quarterbacks didn't play well enough to win the game", Sumrall stated. "They didn't get much help from the people around them either."

The Skinny: First, I want to make one thing clear. This game will always and forever be THE WORLDS LARGEST OUTDOOR COCKTAIL PARTY!!! So stop with all the name changes and disrespectful attempts at recreating something that needs no adjustments!! I digress, but while a lot will be made about the quarterback position at Florida, the inconsistency and at times lack of discipline by this team is frustrating to Sumrall.

Sumrall noted missed assignments, alignments and attention to detail that can't happen in the SEC. Despite being 5-3 with four winnable games ahead, what has been surprising is how this football team despite playing hard cannot get out of its own way at key times in games.

Sumrall continues to build equity among the Gator faithful because he more than anyone understands what it takes to get it done in Gainesville. His team will continue to get in the ring every week and throw blows but at some point, the most important position in sports will have to steady itself so this team can develop with its future at the head of the operation for good.

Unfortunately for Sumrall, neither guy has played well enough to snatch it. At the end of the day the Gators are 5-3 and will be favored in at least three of the next four games, and if you would ask most people if the Gators finish at 9-3 or 8-4, they would live with that. It would also make the Gators Bowl eligible and keep Sumrall off the pavement outside of Ben Hill Griffin Stadium.

A historic meeting with Oklahoma is six days away so the Gators will need to make some decisions and get healthy quick.

Final Score: Georgia 27 Florida 8 (Prediction Georgia 31 Florida 16)

COLUMN · BUDDY MARTIN

"Coach Dumbass" Owns Up To All His Team's Mistakes

By Buddy Martin



Photo: GatorBait Media.

Photo: GatorBait Media

> *"In school we learn that mistakes are bad, and we are punished for making them. Yet, if you look at the way humans are designed to learn, we learn by making mistakes. We learn to walk by falling down. If we never fell down, we would never walk."— Robert T. Kiyosaki, Rich Dad, Poor Dad*

Quick now, how many times have we heard Jon Sumrall exhort his team not to beat itself. Do his players hear him? Well, yes. But hearing and doing are two different things.

As we saw again on Saturday in Atlanta, the sometimes spunky, sometimes scrappy Florida team gave good effort, which was negated by mistakes – sometimes downright stupid mistakes! But here's a little hope without the sales pitch. Here is where I refuse to bury these Gators.

There were plenty of reasons to quit at halftime. Down 24-0. Nothing working consistently. Another Georgia game headed toward that familiar place where Florida fans begin wondering why they didn't take up gardening. But they kept playing.

Brad White's defense, held together in places with baling wire and chewing gum, kept giving the offense another chance.

The Gators didn't surrender a touchdown in the second half. No, that doesn't mean Florida won the second half in any way worth putting on a commemorative T-shirt. Georgia had the lead and could afford to play accordingly. Still, there is a difference between getting beaten and surrendering.

These kids got beat, but I didn't see them surrender. That matters when you're trying to figure out whether a coach has something to build on or just something to clean up.

Sumrall didn't ask anybody to celebrate the effort. "I apologize to our fans. That wasn't what the Gator standard is," he said. "They should be pissed off. I hope they are. I am too. We're going to get this right."

Good. Because the fan base has the first part covered. Getting it right is the part everybody is waiting on.

Give Jones the football

For my money, Tramell Jones Jr. should start next Saturday. Not because he played mistake-free football. He didn't. The strip-sack was devastating, and the interception cost Florida another scoring opportunity. But he moved the offense. He supplied a little electricity to a unit that too often looked as if somebody had forgotten to pay the utility bill.

His legs give Florida an option when the blocking breaks down or the first read disappears.

Right now, this offense needs options considerably more than it needs another explanation. That isn't a declaration that Aaron Philo cannot play. Nor should it become an invitation to pile on a young quarterback who had one interception go through a receiver's hands.

Quarterback debates have a way of turning otherwise reasonable people into angry relatives arguing over the thermostat. You can prefer Jones without treating Philo like a defendant.

I prefer Jones. Let him prepare as the starter. Let him settle into the job. Then find out whether those flashes can become sustained drives instead of interesting little footnotes in another losing afternoon.

Accountability needs a scoreboard

Sumrall's willingness to own his mistake was refreshing. We have all heard coaches explain how a penalty was misunderstood, a situation was complicated or somebody somewhere failed to execute.

This one put the dunce cap on himself. Fine. But accountability cannot end with a memorable quote. Otherwise, it's just another entertaining press conference attached to an aggravating football game.

The coach has to stay where he belongs. The punt-return unit has to let the other fellow punt. The quarterbacks have to protect the ball. And the offense has to stop making the defense spend its afternoon cleaning up after it.

Georgia was good enough without Florida volunteering as the catering service. Now the Gators need one more victory to become bowl eligible.

That remains achievable. It also remains a modest ambition for a program whose fans remember when November conversations involved championships rather than qualifying for another December itinerary.

Nobody needs to apologize for wanting more. But disappointment doesn't require cruelty, either. These are young players trying to find their footing under a new coach.

They deserve honest criticism, not contempt. And their coach deserves time accompanied by evidence — not time accompanied exclusively by promises.

There was a little hope Saturday. Not enough to brighten the scoreboard. Enough to notice that a badly bruised team kept swinging. Now comes the difficult part. Keep the fight. Lose the foolishness.

COLUMN · BUDDY MARTIN

The Receiver Who Caught Everything

By Buddy Martin

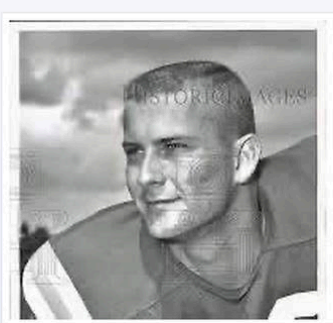


Photo courtesy University of Florida archives.

Charlie Casey. Photo courtesy University of Florida archives.
He wasn't fast. Let's get that out of the way, because Charlie Casey would have told you so himself

He was deliberate. He ran a 10- or 11-yard out route like a man signing his name, the same way every time, and in the mid-1960s, when defensive backs still played soft and nobody had heard of bump-and-run, you could complete that pass just about any time you wanted.

Florida wanted to a lot.

Charlie Casey, the All-American end who caught Steve Spurrier's passes before anybody in the Southeastern Conference really knew what a passing game was, has passed away at 82. When I heard, I went back and watched the old plays. Then I called the Head Ball Coach.

"Charlie was our best receiver my sophomore and junior year," Spurrier said. "He was a year ahead of me. He was a guy that caught everything." He means that almost literally.

The Day Spurrier Directed Traffic

Every Gator of a certain age knows the play. Nov. 27, 1965, Florida Field. Florida State had just driven 86 yards and taken a 17-16 lead with 2:10 left, and 49,513 people were sitting in stunned silence.

Spurrier needed 58 seconds.

Here's how he remembers the touchdown:

"I called a sprint-out, out route. Everybody played off back then. So I rolled out, sort of throw-and-run, and he'd run about a 10-, 11-yard out. One of the FSU guys jumped offside. There was hardly any pass rush at all, and I figured I had a free play. So I just waved him, 'Go deep!'

"You'd think we practiced it all the time. He put his foot in the ground, went deep, and I hit him for the touchdown that put us ahead."

That was the Spurrier "direct traffic" game, long before he was drawing up the Fun 'n' Gun on a visor. A quarterback on the run, pointing his receiver upfield like a cop at a busy intersection, and a receiver smart enough to understand the instructions instantly.

The ball arrived in the end zone with 1:12 to play. Florida won 30-17. Casey caught seven passes for 107 yards that afternoon, according to the Tallahassee Democrat's game account, and the paper's Bill McGrotha wrote that Florida's "two superb All-Americans," Spurrier and Casey, won it.

The One That Got Away

Spurrier can also tell you about the only pass Casey ever dropped. He knows the year, the stadium and the route.

"He'd tell you the one pass he dropped. That was against FSU, at FSU, in '64," Spurrier said. "It was sort of an out-and-up. I hit him, and the safety was coming over. He said, 'I saw the safety coming. I was going to catch it and undercut him, and I just took my eye off the ball for a minute.'

"So he dropped one pass in the two years I got to play with him."

One drop in two years, and 60 years later his quarterback still remembers it. That tells you how rare it was.

The Numbers Behind the Hands

The numbers back up the memory. In 1964 Casey led the SEC with 47 catches for 673 yards, despite being double-teamed routinely. In 1965 he broke his own school records with 58 catches, 809 yards and eight touchdowns, and he finished his career as the leading receiver in SEC history, with 1,612 receiving yards.

He was a first-team All-American by the Associated Press and the coaches in 1965, played in the Senior Bowl, and was an Academic All-American too. He majored in art. He went into the University of Florida Athletic Hall of Fame, and the Florida Sports Hall of Fame as well.

"He was definitely the main target in '65," Spurrier said. He remembers the Sugar Bowl against Missouri on Jan. 1, 1966, when Florida fell behind 20-0 and then put the ball in the air on nearly every down.

"I don't know how many passes he caught in the Sugar Bowl, but it was a bunch of 'em, 'cause we threw almost every down there in the second half."

The Gators completed 27 passes for 352 yards that day. One of them was a 21-yard touchdown to Casey. Florida lost 20-18 after missing three two-point conversions, and Spurrier became the first player from a losing team to be named Sugar Bowl MVP. The quarterback got the trophy. The receiver had a lot to do with it.

The First of His Kind

Near the end of our conversation, Spurrier had one more thought.

"You know what, he might have been Florida's first-ever All-American wide receiver," he said. "Nobody really threw the ball until about '64, '65, right in there. We started throwing a little bit."

Technically, Dale Van Sickel was an All-American end for the Gators back in 1928, in a different game in a different century. But Spurrier's point holds up. Charlie Casey was the first Florida receiver who mattered because the ball was actually coming to him. Carlos Alvarez came later, then Wes Chandler, Cris Collinsworth, Ricky Nattiel, Jack Jackson, Reidel Anthony, Ike Hilliard. Every one of them runs a route that started with Charlie Casey deliberately running an out at Florida Field.

"He was a great guy," Spurrier said. "We all had a lot of fun together. He played golf. He was a pretty decent golfer."

Casey had been in poor health the last several years, living down in Fort Myers. When the 1966 team got together for its reunion this past year, the old Gators thought about him.

"Charlie was a good friend, good guy, wonderful," Spurrier said. "He had a good life."

He wasn't fast. He didn't need to be. He caught everything, except that one in Tallahassee, and Steve Spurrier still hasn't forgotten it.

Rest easy, Charlie. The ball's on its way.

PREGAME ANALYSIS · LOREN MEADOWS

Pregame Analysis: Florida Gators (5-2, 3-2) vs. Georgia Bulldogs (6-1, 4-1)

By Loren Meadows



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Archive photo: Florida's offensive line sets up in front of the quarterback during the Nov. 2, 2024, game against Georgia in Jacksonville.

By Loren Meadows, GatorBaitMedia.com Football Analyst, Host of the Gator Lowdown

Georgia offense

Key players: #14 QB Gunner Stockton (6-1, 215, 5th), #3 RB Nate Frazier (5-10, 205, Jr.), #20 RB Dwight Phillips Jr. (5-10, 185, Jr.), #81 WR Craig Dandridge (6-1, 185, Fr.), #1 WR Talyn Taylor (6-0, 190, So.), #7 TE Lawson Luckie (6-4, 240, Sr.), #16 WR London Humphreys (6-2, 200, Sr.)

Matchups to watch: Georgia offensive line vs. Florida defensive line, Georgia receivers vs. Florida secondary

Georgia offensive coordinator Mike Bobo has an offense that is built on diversity with a heart of physicality. This unit is one of the nation's best at using the run game to build to enough explosive plays that keep opposing defenses off balance and looking for answers. Gunner Stockton leads the cast of characters with great control and command. Prior to an uncanny performance in the loss to Auburn, Stockton had thrown just two interceptions on the year against 14 touchdown passes and still leads the SEC in passing efficiency. Stockton is supported by two talented backs, a steady group of receivers, and arguably the nation's best tight end. Running backs Nate Frazier and Dwight Phillips have combined for 578 yards and seven touchdowns, with Phillips averaging 7.4 yards per carry.

On the outside, Dandridge and Taylor are as talented a young group as the Gators' Brown and Wilson and play well beyond their age. Senior London Humphreys steadies the group and is fearless over the middle. The joker in the deck is tight end Lawson Luckie, who is another matchup nightmare in a long list of great tight ends in Athens. He is fifth on the team in catches (11) and is averaging almost 17 yards per catch. Look for Bobo to use shifts and motions to create space for him and take advantage of the slot similar to the way Missouri used Cayden Lee in Week 5.

The Florida defense seems to be finding its pass rush with five sacks of Arch Manning and 11 tackles for loss. If the Gators can find a way to get pressure with four and drop eight in coverage, Stockton may not be as comfortable with eight defenders staring him in the face in coverage. If the Gators are forced to bring pressure with five or six, Stockton has been very successful against man pressures with his complement of pass catchers. The first down of every series will be key to keep Georgia off schedule in third-and-long situations. If Georgia gets out the gate on every series, a Gator secondary that has been hot and cold could find itself chasing Luckie down the seam consistently.

Georgia defense

Key players: #5 LB Raylen Wilson (6-1, 235, Sr.), #9 LB Chris Cole (6-3, 235, Jr.), #4 S KJ Bolden (6-0, 195, Jr.), #3 OLB Quintavius Johnson (6-4, 255, Jr.), #14 S Rasean Dinkins (5-11, 190, So.)

Matchups to watch: Florida run game vs. Georgia front seven, Gators offensive coordinator Buster Faulkner vs. Kirby Smart

As usual, Georgia begins and ends with great defense. Georgia is surrendering just 276 yards per game, which is third in the SEC and 12th nationally. The Bulldogs also boast the SEC's best scoring defense and are ranked second in the conference against the run. These numbers come courtesy of a deep defensive line that allows the second-level players of Georgia to run downhill and keep the opposing offense under duress. Linebackers Raylen Wilson and Chris Cole are first and second in tackles, tackles for loss and sacks. Wilson, who leads the team with four sacks, is one of only two inside linebackers in the SEC to have at least four sacks. Georgia will bring a number of varied pressures, and when this duo is sent from the inside they come with bad intentions.

On the back end, Georgia is bolstered by preseason All-American KJ Bolden and future star Rasean Dinkins, who has raised his level of play after starting two games as a true freshman in 2025. Both are versatile against the run and the pass and handle the different looks that Smart and staff draw up for the defense. With Jadan Baugh looking to regain his early-season form, it will be Bolden and Dinkins who will be tasked with cleaning up the mess created by the front seven.

Kirby Smart continues to leave his imprint on this side of the ball, where Georgia continues to reload through solid high school recruiting and development. The Gators' offensive coordinator has had success against his former boss, but moving the ball consistently has been tough without the use of smoke and mirrors. The potential return of Vernell Brown, listed as questionable on Friday's availability report, should help Faulkner's schemes, but the Gators will be at a disadvantage against the most talented and deepest defensive line they will see all season. Florida looks to run first to open the rest of the playbook. That is a tall task against this group.

The skinny

The Gators were up against it going into this week as both teams were coming off a much-needed rest. There was also the question of who the Gators would turn to at quarterback after Tramell Jones flashed in place of the injured Aaron Philo against Texas. The story continued to grow legs after both quarterbacks were listed as questionable on Wednesday. There was also a rumor that receiver Dallas Wilson may not be available, although he was not listed on the availability report for this weekend. With questions about who would lead the team and the health of that individual, things just haven't seemed right for a Gator upset. Florida has looked as good as any team in the country dispatching Ole Miss, which throttled Missouri and fell to Texas. They faltered twice and then went to Austin and beat Texas, which found a way to beat Ohio State and dispatch Ole Miss. Simply put, the inconsistency of this Gator team does not build much confidence to snap the five-game losing streak against Georgia. Teams that suck usually don't beat Kirby, especially when the game is basically a home game for Georgia. Philo was reported as the starter on Friday afternoon, and his return to Georgia should have him playing inspired football. Georgia, however, is too talented for the

inconsistent Gators, and minus the Gators replicating Auburn's three turnovers it won't be enough. The Gators show up and play hard but leave 5-3.

Prediction: Georgia 31, Florida 16

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ANALYSIS · GATORBAIT STAFF

Sumrall: Tom Brady Would Have Been 'Under Too Much Duress' Against Georgia

By GatorBait Staff



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Florida coach Jon Sumrall said Monday he is not sure even Tom Brady could have helped the Gators in Saturday's 27-8 loss at Georgia, because of the pressure a quarterback was under.

> *"I don't know if Tom Brady was our quarterback on Saturday if it would have helped us. ... He would have been under too much duress and pressure to operate."*

Sumrall said it is hard to judge the quarterbacks when the team around them is struggling. "It's really hard to fully evaluate the quarterback position when we're not playing good enough around them," he said. "I'd like to see everybody else play a little bit better so that we can fully evaluate what we have going on there."

"We're not playing good enough around them as a team," Sumrall said.

Florida was held to 54 rushing yards on 28 carries, 1.9 yards per attempt, and 252 total yards, according to FloridaGators.com. Georgia ran for 217 yards on 42 carries and finished with 318 total yards. The Gators turned the ball over four times and converted 4 of 12 third downs.

"We had too many balls in jeopardy"

Sumrall did not name a starting quarterback between Aaron Philo and Tramell Jones Jr.

> *"We had too many balls that were in jeopardy with both guys."*

"I need both of them to be ready to be our starter at any point," Sumrall said. "And we're going to move forward with, like, 'Hey man, both of you guys are competing every day.'"

"Here's the official VB3 statement"

Asked about fan narratives that wide receiver Vernell Brown III is not committed enough and does not want to play, Sumrall turned to the camera.

> *"Here's the official VB3 statement. It's the camera right here, all right? He wants to play. He's doing everything he can to play. He's pissed off he can't play, and he's doing everything in his power to play."*

Sumrall said the Gators thought they were past the injury. "It's a real injury that we thought we were on the other side of, that he had a setback last week," he said. "And it sucks. I mean, it freaking sucks for him. It sucks for the team because he helps our team be better."

Florida (5-3, 3-3 SEC) hosts Oklahoma on Saturday, Nov. 7, at 7:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network.

Watch the full press conference

The Brady answer starts at about 16:58. The V3 statement starts at about 26:43.

Video: Florida Gators Football on YouTube.

Editor's note: Quotes are taken from the video of Sumrall's Monday press conference. The Associated Press also reported the Brady, quarterback and Brown comments.

Sumrall says Tom Brady could not have helped Florida against Georgia. Video: The Buddy Martin Show on YouTube.

PREVIEW · GATORBAIT STAFF

No. 1 at Tipoff: Florida Opens Against No. 14 Miami in Tampa

By GatorBait Staff



Photo: GatorBait Media.

TAMPA, Fla. — The No. 1 team in the country has not played a game that counts yet, and its first one is not a soft opener. Florida meets No. 14 Miami on Monday at 6 p.m. ET at Benchmark International Arena in Tampa, with ESPN2 carrying the game.

The Gators earned the top spot in the Associated Press preseason poll released Oct. 19, finishing with 1,461 points. Duke was second with 1,411 and Illinois third with 1,342. That is a 50-point gap over the Blue Devils, which is not much room to hold.

A senior front line

Todd Golden returns a roster with 7 seniors among its 15 players, and the three biggest names in the rotation play up front. Rueben Chinyelu is a 6-foot-10 senior center, Alex Condon a 6-foot-11 senior forward and Thomas Haugh a 6-foot-9 senior forward. All three are listed as seniors on ESPN's roster page.

The backcourt leans on experience too. Denzel Aberdeen (6-5) and Urban Klavzar (6-1) are seniors, and Boogie Fland (6-3) is a junior. Freshmen Arturas Butajevas (6-10) and Jones Lay (6-11) add size off the bench.

What Miami brings

Jai Lucas is the Hurricanes' coach, according to ESPN's team page. Miami also has size and veterans. Malik Reneau is a 6-foot-9 senior forward, Egor Ryzhov a 6-foot-11 senior center and Somto Cyril a 6-foot-11 junior center. Nick Dorn, a 6-foot-7 senior guard, and Brent Bland and Quin Berger, senior guards, give the Hurricanes experience on the perimeter.

The Hurricanes arrive ranked No. 14. Miami's football team is No. 1 in the AP poll this week, so the school is feeling good about its Monday date with the Gators.

The calendar after Tampa

The opener starts a quick November. Florida plays Jacksonville on Nov. 5 at the O'Connell Center, visits Florida State on Nov. 10, hosts Merrimack on Nov. 13, goes to Notre Dame on Nov. 17 and returns home to face Milwaukee on Nov. 24.

Football fans have their own reason to pay attention. The football Gators fell to 5-3 with a 27-8 loss at Georgia on Saturday and are No. 25 in this week's AP poll, so basketball opens with the home crowd in a different mood than a month ago.

Florida basketball does not have to fix anything on Monday night. The Gators only have to show why the poll voters put them first.

ANALYSIS · GATORBAIT STAFF

Florida Won the Punting Battle and Still Lost the Field

By GatorBait Staff

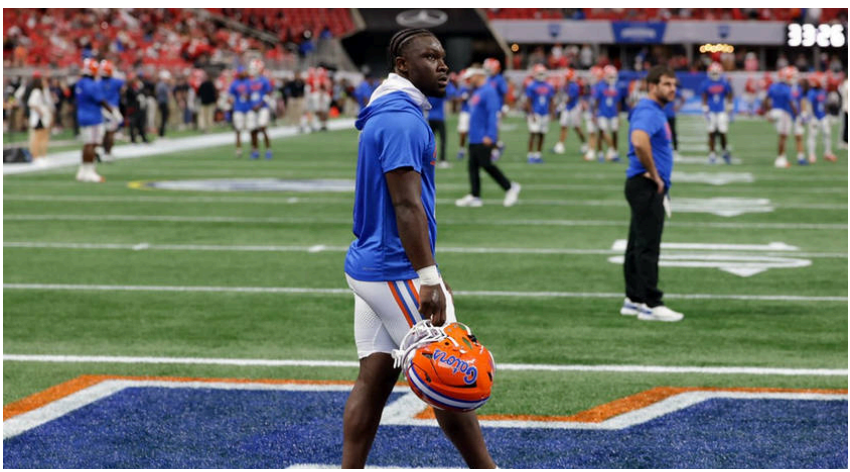


Photo: GatorBait Media.

ATLANTA — Florida had the better punting day in Saturday's 27-8 loss to Georgia at Mercedes-Benz Stadium, and it hardly mattered. The Bulldogs' average drive started at their own 37.3-yard line. Florida's started at its own 27.5. That gap, nearly 10 yards a possession, was built from flags and giveaways, not from the kicking game.

Three 15-yard flags, three scoring drives

Florida was penalized eight times for 78 yards. Georgia was flagged four times for 32. Three of Florida's penalties were 15-yarders, and each one landed on a Georgia scoring drive.

The first came in the opening quarter. Georgia had hurt itself with a holding call and a delay of game and was staring at fourth-and-15 from the Florida 46. Drew Miller's punt went 45 yards to the Florida 1. Then Jaden Edgecombe was flagged for roughing the kicker, and the Bulldogs took over at the Florida 31 with a fresh first down. Nate Frazier scored from the 1 five plays later. Sumrall said of the block attempt: "We don't

leave our feet to block the punt." He added that "our defense had gotten a stop after the pick and then to gift them a new set of downs gave them life."

The second came in the second quarter. Demello Jones intercepted Aaron Philo and returned the ball 23 yards to the Florida 32. An unsportsmanlike conduct flag then moved the ball to the 17. Georgia gained 7 yards on three snaps, and Peyton Woodring kicked a 28-yard field goal for a 10-0 lead.

The third was a face mask on Cormani McClain. On second-and-10 from the Florida 41, Gunner Stockton's pass fell incomplete, and the flag turned a likely third-and-10 into a first down at the Florida 26. Four snaps later, Bo Walker scored from the 1, and Georgia led 17-0 with 1:55 left in the half.

Those three flags took 45 of Florida's 78 penalty yards and fed 17 of the 20 points Georgia's offense produced.

The field-position math

Punting was not the problem. Alec Clark averaged 51.3 yards on four punts, and Miller averaged 49.0 on three. After Miller's punts, Florida started at its own 19, at the Georgia 45 and at its own 33, an average of 35.7 yards from its goal line. After Clark's four punts, Georgia started at its own 41, 19, 11 and 11, an average of 20.5.

The damage came elsewhere. Georgia started three drives in Florida territory: at the Florida 41 after an interception, at the Florida 17 after an interception and a flag, and at the Florida 31 after a Florida turnover on downs. Those starts averaged 70.3 yards from Georgia's goal line. On Georgia's other seven drives, the average start was its own 23.1, worse than Florida's 27.5. Georgia ran 10 drives to Florida's 12, but those three short fields account for the entire gap. Those are the numbers that matter more than any punt Florida launched.

A kickoff added to the tab. After Florida's touchdown, Patrick Durkin's kickoff went out of bounds, and Georgia started at its own 35.

The only touchdown took the hard road

When Florida finally scored, it earned most of it. The drive started at the Georgia 48 after Myles Graham's 42-yard fumble return, and it needed nine plays and 48 yards. Along the way, a sack-fumble cost 10 yards before Jadan Baugh recovered. A third-and-20 produced only 11 yards. Tramell Jones Jr. then found Luke Harpring for 23 yards on fourth-and-9, and a fourth-and-goal pass from the 4 fell incomplete before a Georgia pass interference call put the ball on the 2. Jones ran it in with 6:59 left, and Baugh passed to Dallas Wilson for the two-point conversion.

It was a strange contrast with the third quarter. A Georgia roughing-the-passer flag had wiped out an interception of Jones and given Florida a first down at the Georgia 40. The Gators reached second-and-goal at the 3, and Jones was intercepted in the end zone. The Gators wasted that gift, then needed a fourth-down throw to get the next one.

Georgia closed the book

Georgia answered by running on 11 of its next 12 scrimmage plays and holding the ball for 5:49 of the final 6:59. Dwight Phillips Jr. opened the drive with a 26-yard run, Florida burned two timeouts, and Woodring's 21-yard field goal with 3:34 left made it 27-8. After a Florida turnover on downs, Walker ran four times and Georgia reached fourth-and-1 at the Florida 22. Walker was stopped with 16 seconds left, which gave Florida a last defensive stop and nothing else. Georgia held the ball for 32:10 to Florida's 27:50.

What Florida must clean up before Oklahoma

The trend is encouraging. Florida was flagged five times for 60 yards in the first half, three times for 18 in the second half and not at all in the fourth quarter. The trouble is that the first half decided the game.

Sumrall already has a plan for the film. "It's the self-inflicted ones, the things that we do that are reckless, that hurt ourselves, that I really highlight," he said. "We have a penalty report tape." He said that "we have to clean that up."

Florida (5-3, 3-3 SEC) gets its next chance against Oklahoma on Nov. 7 at 7:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network. A 27.5-yard average start is survivable. Giving the other team a first down and a free 15 yards is not, and the tape

is already cued up.

ANALYSIS · GATORBAIT STAFF

Florida's Offense Dug the Hole on First Down, Then Kept Digging

By GatorBait Staff



Photo: GatorBait Media.

ATLANTA — The postgame conversation about Florida's 27-8 loss to Georgia on Saturday at Mercedes-Benz Stadium has centered on turnovers and flags. The down-and-distance sheet adds a less dramatic cause: Florida's offense kept losing the argument on first down, then spent the rest of every series trying to climb out.

First down went nowhere

According to ESPN's play-by-play, Florida ran 25 first-down snaps and averaged 3.0 yards on them, sacks included. Eleven of the 25 (44 percent) gained nothing or lost ground. That group included five losses, three incompletions, two runs that went nowhere and an interception. Georgia ran 28 first-down snaps, averaged 5.8 and went backward or stood still just four times (14 percent).

The ground game made the gap wider. Georgia's 19 first-down runs, quarterback keepers included, averaged 6.6 yards. Florida's 12 averaged 1.9. Jadan Baugh finished with 17 carries, and five of them lost yardage.

Georgia gained at least four yards on 16 of its 28 first downs. Florida did it on 10 of 25. That gap is the whole afternoon in miniature.

Second-and-long was the toll

A bad first down has a price, and Florida paid it on second down. The Gators faced an average of 8.5 yards to go on second down. Georgia faced just under six. Thirteen of Florida's 20 second-down snaps needed seven yards or more, and 11 of those 13 followed a first-down gain of two yards or fewer. Georgia saw second-and-7 or longer nine times in 20. Per snap, second down was close to a wash, 3.1 yards for Florida and 3.5 for Georgia. The tasks were not close.

Third down is where the bill came due, and the ledger is more interesting than the totals. Georgia converted 6 of 15 third downs and Florida converted 4 of 12, close to the same rate (40 percent to 33 percent). The difference was the distance. Nine of Georgia's 15 third downs were third-and-3 or shorter, and all six of its conversions came there. Florida faced one third-and-short all game, a third-and-2 in the third quarter that Baugh lost 2 yards on.

When Florida got a manageable down, it moved the chains. The Gators converted three of four third-and-6-through-8 situations. When the sheet read third-and-9 or longer, they were 1 for 7, and those seven situations averaged 12.7 yards to go. Georgia went 0 for 6 on third-and-4 or longer, so Florida's defense held up on the hard downs. It just rarely had to play them.

Florida's four conversions were all gains of 10 or more: 10 yards on third-and-6 twice, 14 on third-and-8 and 17 on third-and-9. They came two in the second quarter and two in the third. The Gators were 0 for 2 in the first quarter and 0 for 3 in the fourth.

Eleven negative plays

Florida did a lot of the digging itself. ESPN credits Georgia with 11 tackles for loss, four of them sacks, and Khamari Brooks led the way with two. Florida's defense had four. Nine of the Gators' 11 negative plays came on first or second down.

The costliest came in the fourth quarter. A sack-fumble that Baugh recovered cost 10 yards and turned second-and-10 into third-and-20. Tramell Jones Jr. hit Bailey Stockton for 11 on third down, and Florida still needed a 23-yard completion to Luke Harpring on fourth-and-9 to keep the drive alive. Earlier, in the first quarter, a 3-yard loss on a completion to Eric Singleton Jr. and a 3-yard loss on a Baugh run turned first-and-10 into third-and-16.

Florida's only touchdown came on a drive that needed that fourth-and-9 throw and a Georgia pass interference flag on fourth-and-goal, not on a third-down conversion. That is the hard road, and it is the only one the offense found.

What it means for the offense

The fix sounds simple, which makes it harder to excuse. Nobody has to invent anything new. Sumrall said the staff knew the assignment: "we knew coming into this game we needed to stay ahead of the chains and give ourselves an opportunity." The first-down numbers say Florida never found its way ahead of them.

Sumrall pointed to more than the line. "We had receivers misaligned today, not run the right route, or run the wrong route a handful of times," he said. He also said: "I didn't think we played up front good enough, though, on the offensive line to help them." Both problems show up first on first down, where a four-yard gain turns a series into a menu instead of a math problem.

That matters for the quarterback discussion, too. Sumrall said he did not think it was fair to fully evaluate either Aaron Philo or Jones because "I don't think there was enough help around them." The chain data lines up with that. A quarterback who sees second-and-8.5 and third-and-9.75 on average has little room to work, however clean his day. The first-down fix belongs to everybody: protection, route running and a ground game that has to give more than 1.9 yards a carry on first down.

Florida (5-3, 3-3 SEC) gets its next chance to prove it can start series cleanly against Oklahoma on Nov. 7 at 7:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network. The Gators do not need a trick play to stay ahead of the chains. They need first downs that gain four yards, and Georgia showed on Saturday what that looks like.

ANALYSIS · GATORBAIT STAFF

Georgia Lived on Third-and-1. Florida Rented Third-and-Long.

By GatorBait Staff



Photo: GatorBait Media.

ATLANTA — Turnovers will get the headlines from Florida's 27-8 loss to Georgia on Saturday at Mercedes-Benz Stadium. The down-and-distance sheet tells a quieter story: Georgia spent the afternoon on third-and-short, and Florida spent it begging for a miracle.

The game was won on first down

According to ESPN's play-by-play, Georgia averaged 5.8 yards on its 28 first-down snaps (163 yards). Florida averaged 3.0 on 25 (76 yards). Second down was roughly a wash. By third down, the gap was a canyon.

Georgia needed an average of 5 yards on its 15 third downs. Nine of them were third-and-3 or shorter, six were third-and-1, and the Bulldogs converted five of those six. Florida needed an average of 9.75 yards on its 12. Seven were third-and-9 or longer, and the Gators converted one. Florida faced exactly one third-and-short all night, a third-and-2 in the third quarter that Jadan Baugh lost 2 yards on.

Here is the twist: Georgia was 0-for-6 whenever it needed 4 yards or more, so Florida's defense did its job on the hard downs. It just rarely got to play them.

Florida's offense, meanwhile, built its own long yardage. Five of those seven long third downs followed a loss of yardage. The third-and-16 came after back-to-back 3-yard losses. The third-and-20 came after a sack that cost 10 yards. Georgia's defense finished with 11 tackles for loss, including four sacks, to Florida's four. Florida's offense lost yardage on 11 snaps; Georgia's lost yardage on four.

Sumrall said the Gators entered the game aware of it: "we knew coming into this game we needed to stay ahead of the chains and give ourselves an opportunity." The numbers say they spent the night behind them.

Three 15-yard gifts, three scoring drives

Florida was flagged eight times for 78 yards. Georgia was flagged four times for 32. The totals have been written about. The distribution has not.

Three of Florida's penalties were 15-yarders, and together they account for 45 of the 78 yards. Each landed on a Georgia scoring drive, and each came with a first down.

In the first quarter, a roughing-the-kicker call erased a 45-yard punt that would have pinned Florida at its own 1. Georgia took over at the Florida 31 and Nate Frazier scored five plays later. In the second quarter, an unsportsmanlike-conduct flag turned a 23-yard interception return into a drive start at the Florida 17. Georgia gained 7 yards and Peyton Woodring kicked a 28-yard field goal. Later in the quarter, a face mask on a second-and-10 incompletion moved the ball from the Florida 41 to the 26, and Bo Walker scored from the 1.

That is 17 of Georgia's 20 offensive points. The other seven of its 24 first-half points came on Chris Cole's 66-yard fumble return. Georgia's offense did not score in the first half without a 15-yard assist.

The Gators did clean it up. They had five penalties for 60 yards in the first half, three for 18 in the second half and none in the fourth quarter. Field position never recovered, though. Georgia's average drive started at its

own 37.3-yard line. Florida's started at its own 27.5, even with Alec Clark averaging 51.3 yards on four punts to Drew Miller's 49.0 on three.

The only touchdown took the hard road

Florida's first points came with 6:59 left in the fourth quarter, 53 minutes and 1 second into the game. When the Gators finally strung a drive together, they needed everything. It covered nine plays and 48 yards, and it survived a sack-fumble that Baugh recovered, a third-and-20 that Tramell Jones Jr. hit for 11, a fourth-and-9 that Jones turned into a 23-yard completion to Luke Harpring and a fourth-and-goal from the 4 that ended in a Georgia pass interference call. Jones ran in from the 2, and Baugh threw to Dallas Wilson for the two-point conversion.

It also kept alive Florida's NCAA-record streak of games without being shut out. Florida finished 4-for-12 on third down and 1-for-2 on fourth, and its touchdown drive needed one of those fourth-down conversions and one Georgia flag.

Georgia answered by running on 11 of its next 12 scrimmage plays and holding the ball for 5:49 of the final 6:59. The Gators did get one last stop, on fourth-and-1 at the Florida 22 with under 20 seconds left, but by then the clock had done its damage.

Florida (5-3, 3-3 SEC) gets its next chance to make third down simple against Oklahoma on Nov. 7 at 7:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network.

ROUNDUP · GATORBAIT STAFF

Halloween Saturday: 21 Ranked Teams Have Fallen in Three Weeks, and Miami and Ohio State Take Road Tests

By GatorBait Staff



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

ESPN's Week 9 preview counts 21 ranked teams beaten over the last three weeks, more than half of them by unranked opponents, with a top-two team losing to an unranked team each week.

The AP poll shows it. BYU, No. 2 a week earlier, fell to No. 8 in the Oct. 25 poll, Texas Tech dropped from No. 8 to No. 13 and Ole Miss from No. 7 to No. 12. Texas jumped from No. 19 to No. 11 and Utah from No. 10 to No. 6. Miami (7-0) is No. 1 with 59 first-place votes, followed by Ohio State, Georgia, Indiana and Notre Dame.

The biggest tests

No. 1 Miami at North Carolina, 7:30 p.m. ET, ABC. ESPN's preview notes that Miami has played only one opponent in the top 40 of its SP+ ratings so far.

No. 2 Ohio State at USC, 7:30 p.m., NBC. Quarterback Julian Sayin is out indefinitely with an arm injury, ESPN reports, and the Buckeyes will turn to freshman Luke Fahey or sophomore Tavien St. Clair. USC managed seven points against Wisconsin.

No. 6 Utah (7-0) at Cincinnati, 3:45 p.m., ESPN. The Bearcats beat Texas Tech a week ago and are strong at home this season, per ESPN's preview.

No. 22 Arizona at No. 13 Texas Tech, noon, ESPN. Both teams entered 6-1; Texas Tech won 34-26.

No. 20 Northwestern at Oregon, 3:30 p.m., Peacock. Chip Kelly, Oregon's former head coach, now runs a Northwestern offense that ESPN's preview describes as resurgent.

Minnesota at No. 4 Indiana, 3:30 p.m., CBS. ESPN's preview says Indiana quarterback Josh Hoover is dealing with an injury to his throwing arm.

The playoff clock

The College Football Playoff committee releases its first top 25 Tuesday, Nov. 3, from 7 to 8 p.m. ET on ESPN. NCAA.com lists six rankings shows this season, with the last on Sunday, Dec. 6.

Cover photo: Florida and Ole Miss defenders meet in Gainesville on Sept. 26. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Sources: ESPN (Week 9 preview, AP poll and scoreboard); NCAA.com (CFP rankings schedule).

REPORT · GATORBAIT STAFF

Pouncey, Emmitt Smith Inducted Into Florida-Georgia Hall of Fame

By GatorBait Staff



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Former Florida stars Maurkice Pouncey and Emmitt Smith were inducted into the Florida-Georgia Hall of Fame on Friday, one day before the No. 17 Gators play No. 3 Georgia in Atlanta, FloridaGators.com reported.

The induction ceremony and luncheon, presented by Miller Electric Company, took place at the Chick-fil-A College Football Hall of Fame. Kickoff Saturday at Mercedes-Benz Stadium is set for 3:30 p.m. ET on ABC. Florida is 5-2 overall and 3-2 in the SEC. Georgia is 6-1 and 4-1, according to ESPN.

Pouncey played at Florida from 2007 to 2009, a span in which the Gators went 36-5, won two SEC championships and captured the 2008 BCS National Championship. He faced Georgia three times and helped Florida win in 2008 and 2009, protecting Heisman Trophy winner Tim Tebow.

A Freshman All-American in 2007, Pouncey became the first Florida player to win the Rimington Trophy, given to the nation's top center, in 2009. He also was a consensus first-team All-American and first-team All-SEC pick. Pittsburgh selected him 18th overall in the 2010 NFL Draft. In an 11-year NFL career, he made nine Pro Bowls and was a two-time first-team All-Pro.

Smith played at Florida from 1987 to 1989 and left as the school's career rushing leader with 3,928 yards and 36 touchdowns. He ran for 224 yards in his first collegiate start in 1987, one of several standout games against Georgia. As a junior, he rushed for 1,599 yards and was a consensus first-team All-American and the SEC Most Valuable Player.

Dallas took Smith in the first round of the 1990 NFL Draft. During a 15-year NFL career he became the league's all-time leading rusher, won three Super Bowls, earned NFL MVP and Super Bowl XXVIII MVP honors and made eight Pro Bowls. He is a member of both the College Football Hall of Fame and the Pro Football Hall of Fame.

The Georgia-Florida Hall of Fame was established in 1995 and has honored more than 100 people. Gators already inducted include Steve Spurrier, Danny Wuerffel, Tim Tebow and Fred Taylor. Georgia inductees include Vince Dooley, Herschel Walker, David Pollack and Knowshon Moreno.

This year's game is the first in the series played in Atlanta, per ESPN. The rivalry moves to Tampa in 2027 and returns to Jacksonville in 2028, FloridaGators.com reported.

Sources: FloridaGators.com (Oct. 30 release); ESPN.

Cover photo: Florida and Georgia players meet at the line of scrimmage during the teams' game in Jacksonville on Nov. 2, 2024. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

ROUNDUP · GATORBAIT STAFF

SEC Saturday: Kentucky Leads at 5-1, Nine Teams Hold AP Spots and Next Week Is Loaded

By GatorBait Staff



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Five SEC games are on the board Saturday, and only one pairs two ranked teams: No. 17 Florida at No. 3 Georgia, 3:30 p.m. ET on ABC at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Alabama, Kentucky, LSU, Tennessee, Texas A&M and Vanderbilt are off, according to ESPN's schedule.

Where the SEC stands

Entering Saturday, ESPN's standings have Kentucky (7-1 overall) in front at 5-1 in conference play and Georgia (6-1) at 4-1. Alabama is 4-2. LSU, Tennessee, Florida and Ole Miss are each 3-2. Missouri, Texas and Oklahoma are 2-2, Mississippi State, Auburn and South Carolina are 2-3, Arkansas is 1-3, Texas A&M is 1-4 and Vanderbilt is 0-5.

Nine SEC teams were in the AP Top 25 released Oct. 25: Georgia (No. 3), Kentucky (9), Alabama (10), Texas (11), Ole Miss (12), LSU (15), Tennessee (16), Florida (17) and Missouri (23). Georgia is the league's highest-ranked team, behind Miami and Ohio State.

Saturday's SEC games

Auburn at No. 12 Ole Miss, 12:45 p.m., SEC Network.

No. 17 Florida at No. 3 Georgia, 3:30 p.m., ABC. Georgia is a 12.5-point favorite with a total of 56.5.

South Carolina at Oklahoma, 4:15 p.m., SEC Network. Oklahoma is favored by 3.5 with a total of 44.5. Both teams are 4-3.

Mississippi State at No. 11 Texas, 7:30 p.m., ESPN. Texas is favored by 20.5 with a total of 50.5.

No. 23 Missouri at Arkansas, 7:45 p.m., SEC Network. Missouri is favored by 10 with a total of 48.5.

Lines are DraftKings' as listed by ESPN and can change before kickoff. ESPN's Week 9 preview noted that Georgia lost to Auburn two weeks ago and has fumbled six times in its last two games, and that Florida's defense ranks 97th nationally in points allowed per drive.

What comes next

The College Football Playoff committee releases its first top 25 Tuesday, Nov. 3, from 7 to 8 p.m. ET on ESPN, according to NCAA.com's schedule.

The SEC's next Saturday, Nov. 7, is crowded, per ESPN's schedule: Alabama at LSU at 3:30 p.m. on ABC, Kentucky at Tennessee at 6:15 p.m. on ESPN, Georgia at Ole Miss at 7:30 p.m. on ABC and Oklahoma at

Florida at 7:45 p.m. on SEC Network. ESPN's preview called the Alabama-LSU, Georgia-Ole Miss and Kentucky-Tennessee games a shake-up for the conference no matter how they finish.

Cover photo: Florida and Ole Miss met in Gainesville on Sept. 26. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Sources: ESPN (scoreboard, standings, AP poll, Week 9 preview and odds from DraftKings); NCAA.com (CFP rankings schedule).

REPORT · GATORBAIT STAFF

Georgia-Born Gator: Reports Say Aaron Philo Will Start Against Georgia

By GatorBait Staff



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Florida quarterback Aaron Philo (No. 12) with teammates after Florida beat Ole Miss on Sept. 26, 2026. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media. GAINESVILLE — Aaron Philo is expected to lead Florida into Saturday's rivalry game against Georgia, according to Friday reports from CBS Sports and The Associated Press.

CBS Sports, citing a source familiar with the decision, reported that Philo will return as the starter after a throwing-shoulder injury. The Associated Press separately reported the same decision while noting that coach Jon Sumrall had not made it public.

That distinction matters. Florida's SEC availability reports earlier in the week listed both Philo and backup Tramell Jones Jr. as questionable. Friday's reporting is not the same as a formal Florida announcement, and GatorBait will update this story if the Gators issue one or release a new availability designation.

Philo, No. 12, gives Florida a Georgia-born quarterback for the rivalry's first move to Atlanta. The 6-foot-1, 207-pound junior from Bogart, Georgia, is in his first Florida season after transferring from Georgia Tech, according to the Gators' official roster.

In six games, Philo has completed 105 of 149 passes for 1,341 yards, nine touchdowns and three interceptions, according to Florida's official statistics.

A shoulder injury kept him out of Florida's 27-24 win at Texas on Oct. 17, when Jones made his first career start. Jones completed 22 of 35 passes for 155 yards and two touchdowns without an interception, leaving Florida with a tested contingency if the injury picture changes.

No. 17 Florida (5-2, 3-2 SEC) meets No. 3 Georgia (6-1, 4-1) at 3:30 p.m. ET Saturday on ABC at Mercedes-Benz Stadium. It is the first Florida-Georgia game played in Atlanta while Jacksonville's EverBank Stadium undergoes renovation.

The rivalry long known as the World's Largest Outdoor Cocktail Party is temporarily moving indoors, but not losing any of its temperature. For Florida, the reported quarterback decision puts a Georgia-raised Gator at the center of it.

Earlier this week, The Buddy Martin Show took on the quarterback question Friday reporting now addresses.

COLUMN · FRANZ BEARD

The Soothsayer: Georgia in a heart stopper

By Franz Beard



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Florida receiver Vernell Brown III stands on the field in The Swamp with a hand raised to his helmet. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Third-ranked Georgia (6-1, 4-1 SEC) has every reason to feel confident Saturday when it takes on 17th-ranked Florida (5-2, 3-2 SEC). The Bulldogs are healthy and they've had a week to get the bad taste of losing to Auburn out of their mouths, plus instead of Jacksonville they get the Gators in their own back yard. Georgia is a 12.5-point favorite and you wonder why the margin isn't more considering Florida has not one, but two gimpy quarterbacks.

Everything points to Georgia winning this one big.

Of course, everything pointed to Texas blowing out the Gators two weeks ago, too, and we know how that turned out. Texas, also, was a 12.5-point favorite and playing at home in Austin. The Gators sprung the upset by changing defensive strategies, blitzing on nearly every snap to force Arch Manning to throw before his receivers could get any real separation. Five Florida sacks later, the Gators left Austin with a shocking 27-24 win over the Longhorns, who were ranked No. 1 in the nation just two weeks earlier.

Florida ran a very conservative offensive scheme against Texas, in part because Tramell Jones Jr. was making his first collegiate start at quarterback but also because ball control kept the UF defense off the field. In a second half in which the Gators outscored Texas 17-7, Florida possessed the football for nearly 22 minutes. Starting with a drive that

consumed eight minutes after the second half kickoff, the Gators kept moving the chains with a scheme that chipped away at the Texas defense. By the fourth quarter Florida's 3-yard gains were going for four and five, then on the game-winning drive Jadan Baugh busted loose with a 13-yarder that helped set up his 11-yard touchdown that sealed the deal.

Can the Gators do it again? We don't know who will be the QB: Jones who beat Texas on the road in his first start ever or Aaron Philo, the starter in games one through six? There is a prevailing thought that Jon Sumrall already knows who will start but he's not saying because he wants Georgia defensive coaches to burn the midnight oil scheming for each one. If there is an advantage it would seem to be Jones. After all, he brought the Gators back from a 14-point deficit to win and on the road no less. Philo had two golden opportunities to rally the troops in the losses to Missouri and South Carolina but failed to inspire.

To beat Georgia, Florida has to put enough pressure on Gunner Stockton that he melts down as he did against Auburn with two second half interceptions and the fumble that set up Auburn's game-winning field goal. And, the offensive line has to grind away, helping to turn the three-yard gains in the first half into four, five and six as they wear down the Georgia defensive front seven. If Jadan Baugh can run for 90 or more yards, you have to like Florida's chances to have a shot at a win in the fourth quarter.

Two wins over top ten teams – then No. 4 Ole Miss and then No. 7 Texas – should have prepped the Gators for a game against a Georgia team that many are still saying has the best chance of any team in the country to win a national championship. So much depends on the first quarter. If the Auburn game is the fluke that Georgia folks would like us to believe, then the Bulldogs will apply the early pressure to force mistakes that lead to first quarter points. Florida has to be prepared for an onslaught designed to break the Gators' spirit. The Gators must emerge from the first quarter either tied or leading. They can't let Georgia have an early confidence advantage, especially since the game is played in Atlanta. Tickets are supposedly split down the middle but Georgia fans have dominated the after market purchases. Make no mistake about it, this will be a Georgia home game.

This is a very tough call for the Soothsayer, who has spent the week being reminded that Florida damn near beat the Bulldogs last year. Georgia was a better team this time a year ago and Florida was being coached by Billy Napier. Enough said about that! The Gators are improved, however, and that has to be noted. Improved enough to win?

The Sayer Says Sooth!: It is tempting to call this one for Florida. The Gators have incentive and they're battle tested both home and on the road but they already have two SEC losses. A third and their chances of playing in the conference championship game are history. With only that Auburn loss, Georgia does some wiggle room. One more loss won't end their playoff or SEC hopes. As much as it pains the Soothsayer, the call is for Georgia to win, but only after the Gators make their fans hold their hearts while thinking the widow maker is on its way.

THE SEC SOOTHSAYER

Mississippi State (4-3, 2-3 SEC) at No. 11 Texas (5-2, 2-2 SEC): The Longhorns got back in the hunt for both the SEC Championship Game and the College Football Playoff last week when they took down Ole Miss, this despite Arch Manning throwing two more picks. The Longhorns have a world class defense and they have to cover for their quarterback, who has turned brain farting into an art form. There is no denying Arch Manning's physical gifts. There is also no denying that he has the attention span of an earthworm, which is to say Arch has this nasty habit of losing focus which in turn makes Will Muschamp's defensive troops defend a short field. Kamario Taylor, the marvelously gifted sophomore quarterback, could have made this game interesting but he's out for the rest of the season, which is a kind way of saying Mississippi State is toast. The Sayer Says Sooth!: Texas is favored by 20.5 points. The only way the Longhorns win by 20 or fewer points is if Arch has one of those Arch kind of games. The good news for the Longhorns is he can have one of those Arch kind of games and the Longhorns will win quite handily.

Auburn (4-3, 2-3 SEC) at No. 12 Ole Miss (5-2, 3-2 SEC): If Auburn plays like it did two weeks ago when the Tigers did the unthinkable by beating then No. 1 Georgia in Athens, then this game will be very, very interesting. If and when Byrum Brown gets on a roll, which is to say doing a reasonable Lamar Jackson impersonation, the Tigers are very capable. The Ole Miss defense is vulnerable, which it showed last week

when Texas hung 34 on the Rebels. Ole Miss doesn't pressure quarterbacks very well, but the Rebels haven't had the privilege of bull rushing the Auburn O-line. Auburn has given up 30 sacks, last in the SEC and nearly last in the entire country. Any Heisman hopes Trinidad Chambliss has are flickering right now so he can't afford anything less than spectacular. He'll have to do it without Kewan Lacy, whose ailing shoulder sidelines him. The Sayer Says Sooth!: The Rebels are 11.5-point favorites at home in Oxford. The spread should probably be larger but there is no telling which Auburn team shows up. The one that beat Georgia could win this game. Ole Miss can still make it to Atlanta for the SEC Championship Game and the College Football Playoff with a win. The Rebels will keep the hope fire burning.

No. 23 Missouri (5-2, 2-2 SEC) at Arkansas (3-4, 1-3 SEC): The way Ole Miss battered Mizzou two weeks ago has made the Tigers an afterthought when it comes to CFP hopes, but they're still in the hunt. And, this week they get Ahmad Hardy back for the first time this season. If he's fully recovered from the gunshot wound he makes Missouri a very dangerous team. Arkansas is going nowhere. To the Hogs' credit, they got a win over Vanderbilt so they won't have an oh-fer season in SEC play, but they won't be favored any game the rest of the season starting Saturday. They're 10 point home dogs, a number that gives off the feeling that the oddmakers in Las Vegas have little respect for Missouri. The Sayer Says Sooth!: Missouri almost certainly wins this game even with a below average effort but considering the next three games (Texas, at Georgia, Kentucky) the Tigers need to create some semblance of momentum. The Tigers are going to win this one. Anything less than a two-touchdown win is a bad omen for Mizzou moving forward.

South Carolina (4-3, 2-3 SEC) at Oklahoma (4-3, 2-2 SEC): The Save Shane Tour takes to the road to Norman where Oklahoma's ferocious defense awaits LaNorris Sellers, who is playing semi-brilliant once again. If Sellers goes into a quarterbacking coma, which means escaping the pass rush like Houdini and throwing pinpoint passes, the Fighting Chickens have a reasonable shot to win this one. As it stands right now, South Carolina needs three wins or Shane Beamer can kiss this job good bye. Oklahoma can salvage its season by ripping off some wins but doing that will require John Mateer to remember he gives the Sooners their best chance to win when he throws the football to

teammates instead of the opposing defense. For Oklahoma to have any chance the defense is going to have to keep Sellers in the pocket. If he gets loose, they are in trouble. The Sayer Says Sooth!: Oklahoma is a 3-point favorite which tells us the oddsmakers in Las Vegas don't trust the Sooners as far as they can throw them. Probably the big question here is which team will be the most motivated? South Carolina which needs to win at least three more games to save the coach's job or Oklahoma which still has faint hopes of the playoff? The thought is Okie in a chest clutcher.

COLUMN · EDDIE GILLEY

Key to a Win in Atlanta

By Eddie Gilley



Archive photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Archive photo: A Florida quarterback prepares to throw as a Georgia defender closes during the Nov. 2, 2024 rivalry game in Jacksonville. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

The Gators will look to accomplish something that they haven't done in the last five seasons, beat the Georgia Bulldogs on Saturday. Maybe the change of scenery will do the Gators some good. The Dogs have owned them for the last few years in EverBank Stadium in Jacksonville. It's not the longest winning streak for the Dogs, that would be seven and is the

same for the Gators, but it is getting close! Now the game will be played at the Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta and will definitely have a different feel than the annual Largest Outdoor Cocktail Party!

There are a lot of ways that Florida could win this game. Gunner Stockton could have the worst game of his career and gift the Gators with a couple of pick sixes or the vaunted Georgia defense could fall apart and the Gators could make a push to Baugh to win the Heisman with a four touchdown and 200 rushing yard game. Neither of those are likely, but they could happen!

A more realistic key to winning the game in Atlanta will be winning the third down challenge for the Gators. The Bulldogs are converting nearly 54% of their third downs on offense. That ranks them #5 nationally and #1 in the SEC in that category. They have been able to be that effective because they have been so good at running the ball on first down and getting positive yards on second down, leaving them third and short on many occasions. The Gator defense has given up almost 44% conversions on third downs to their opponents. That puts them far down the list in that category. The good news is they held Texas to only 20% in their last game.

The Gator offense is converting only 45% of the time on third down this season. The Georgia defense is only allowing their opponents to convert on third down 36 percent of the time. That's one of the reasons they are one of the best defensive units in the country. Auburn was able to beat them in their last game, but they only converted 6 of 16 on third downs in that game. That's 37.5% for us non math majors.

The key for Florida winning the game on Saturday will come down to a rather simple statistic. Can Florida convert 40% of their third down attempts and can they hold Georgia to under 50% of their third down attempts. If Florida can keep the ball away from the Georgia offense, they have a better chance to win the game. To do so, they must convert third downs when necessary. This will lead to winning the time of possession battle as well.

On defense, if Florida can get the Bulldogs off the field on third down, they can limit the chances they have to make explosive plays. Georgia is averaging 16.7 explosive plays per game this season. Obviously, limiting

the number of total plays will help limit the number of explosive plays given up by the Gator defense that has been suspect at times during the season so far.

If the Gators are to pull the upset in Atlanta, how they fare on both sides of the ball on third down will be a key factor. Time will tell if it is THE key to the success of the Gators or not.

COLUMN · FRANZ BEARD

Why I despise the Georgia Bulldogs and why you should too

By Franz Beard



Archive photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Archive photo: A Florida quarterback prepares to throw as a Georgia defender closes during the Nov. 2, 2024 rivalry game in Jacksonville. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

For the most part, this is a repeat of my yearly ritual of pointing out my intense dislike for the Georgia Bulldogs. Not just the Georgia football team, mind you, but the entire athletic program from top to bottom.

Some people tell me that to despise something as much as I despise the Georgia Bulldogs isn't healthy, but I'm 75 years old and I've been carrying this for decades. It hasn't killed me yet. A pastor friend of mine has told

me I must forgive Georgia for their transgressions, both real and perceived. Forgive? That's Biblical. I can do that. Forget? Not as long as I have a breath to breathe and a functioning brain.

So here goes my annual reminder to all Gator fans that there should be a part of your heart and mind reserved for a never-ending, passionate loathing of the Georgia Bulldogs.

Several times each year well-intentioned people inform me that while I am a Gator, I must cheer for the other 15 teams in the Southeastern Conference whenever they play a non-SEC opponent, no matter the sport, but especially football. How about 14 out of 15 I usually reply, followed by this statement: There is only one reason and one reason only to ever cheer for the Georgia Bulldogs and that is if Georgia winning helps the Florida Gators win a championship. Let's say the Gators need a win and an LSU loss to win the SEC championship and LSU is playing Georgia. In that instance, I will lower myself to cheer grudgingly for Georgia.

But I feel dirty doing it.

In the past I have written that during the War of Northern Aggression, General William Tecumseh Sherman made one serious mistake when he began his march to the sea. It would have taken only a couple days march and his army would have been in Athens where they could have burned down the University of Georgia campus and then salted the earth so that nothing could grow there for more than 100 years.

Have you ever wondered why people who call themselves well educated – graduates of what many call the Redneck Cultural Center of North Georgia – call their team the DAWGS? Maybe if UGa grads could spell the school might be a member of the prestigious American Association of Universities. Florida is a longstanding member and is now considered one of the Public Ivies. Our grads know how to spell.

Perhaps you think the Florida-Georgia game is only one day of the year and that it's cute when they call themselves the Dawgs, but allow me this refresher course on why it is important the other 364 days to have the white hot intensity of 10,000 suns when it comes to passionate contempt for Georgia.

1. THE 1942 GAME

I wasn't even an idea in 1942 when my father was a 17-year-old second semester freshman on the University of Florida campus, biding his time until he was 18 so he could enlist in the Navy. The Gators were expected to field a fine football team in 1942, but most of the able-bodied football players enlisted and the team was decimated. The 1941 Gators had finished 4-6 beating Miami and Georgia Tech before losing by three to UCLA, a game played two weeks after Pearl Harbor. Hope of an outstanding 1942 team was lost when most of the players expected to return enlisted in the military, leaving Tom Lieb with a team made up mostly of players either too young to enlist or unable to pass the military physical.

Coach Thomas Lieb's 1942 Gators were a shell of the team that was envisioned prior to Pearl Harbor. The Gators were a team made up mostly of players either too young to enlist or ones who couldn't pass the military physical. Meanwhile up at Georgia, Wally Butts assembled a dream team. Georgia had one of the best ROTC programs in the country and had been selected for a Navy Pre-Flight program. As players from around the country poured into Athens for Pre-Flight and ROTC, Georgia's already strong roster became stacked. The roster included "Flatfoot" Frankie Sinkwich, who would win the Heisman Trophy; Charlie Trippi, who would win MVP of the Rose Bowl and probably should have won the Heisman in 1946 when he came back from military service; All-American end George Poschner, who would win the Distinguished Service Cross at the Battle of the Bulge; and Gene Ellenson, a great defensive lineman who would have two Silver Stars pinned on him by General George S. Patton for heroism at The Battle of the Bulge. Yes, the same Gene Ellenson who would later become the defensive coordinator at the University of Florida and should have been the successor to Ray Graves, but that is another story for another time.

When the Gators limped into Jacksonville's Fairfield Stadium, the Gators had lost three straight games. Georgia, meanwhile, was 7-0 and fresh off a 21-10 win over third-ranked Alabama. For all practical purposes, the game was over almost before it began, but Wally Butts wouldn't sub in his second and third-teamers, leaving his starters in the game until it was almost over. Final score, Georgia 75, Florida 0. Georgia won the national championship by beating UCLA in the Rose Bowl.

My dad and other Gators I talked to who were part of that greatest generation that went on to serve our nation and win a war in Europe and the Pacific, never forgot how Wally Butts chose to humiliate the Gators when it was obvious UF could offer little to no resistance. Every single one of them was bitter and the mention of Wally Butts made their blood boil.

2. THE 1968 GAME

Florida was picked in the preseason to win the SEC for the first time, finish top five nationally and challenge for the national championship. Four straight wins and a No. 7 national ranking into the season, the Gators met up with the elements in Chapel Hill where they fumbled seven times in the mud and lost to North Carolina. The bottom fell out with a tie at Vanderbilt and a Homecoming loss to Auburn. The Gators were 4-2-1 when they arrived in Jacksonville. Georgia, meanwhile, was 5-0-2, ranked 9th and closing in on Vince Dooley's second SEC championship.

Beginning with the loss to Carolina, Florida was a team with issues that included a quarterback controversy that divided the offense almost straight down the middle. Half wanted Larry Rentz while the other half wanted Jackie Eckdahl. Defensive players on the other side of the locker room were resentful that their teammates were selfish enough to split loyalties.

As if things weren't bad enough, play caller and offensive backfield coach Fred Pancoast was hospitalized for an appendectomy a few days prior to the game in Jacksonville. Feeling the need to shake up the team Ray Graves decided to swap coordinators – Ed Kensler became the defensive coordinator and Gene Ellenson became the offensive coordinator.

The only thing shaken was the team's confidence and it showed on that miserably cold, rainy day at the Gator Bowl. I was working for the Gainesville Sun at that time but press box space at the old Gator Bowl was limited. My boss, Joe Halberstein, got me a ticket to watch from the stands where there was no relief from the weather. By the second quarter, I was soaked to the core and I was freezing. Since I was riding with other Sun staffers, I had to stay to the bitter end asking myself if this was what hypothermia was all about.

It was seek and destroy for Georgia. Mike Cavan quarterbacked Georgia to a 41-0 lead at the half and the defense led by future College Football Hall of Famers Bill Stanfill and Jake Scott, made the Gators pay on nearly every play. The Gators didn't cross midfield until the third quarter.

In the final minute of the game with the score 48-0, Georgia faced a fourth down when one of the players on the team approached Dooley and told him he hadn't kicked a field goal since high school. Rather than take a knee to end the game, Dooley called time and sent the player in to kick the field goal to humiliate Florida 51-0.

As was his habit on Saturdays upon seeing the Florida football score, San Francisco 49ers backup QB Steve Spurrier called Ellenson to talk about the game. If you've ever wondered why Spurrier was obsessed with running up the score on Georgia whenever he had the chance, the conversation he had with Coach Ellenson is one of the main reasons. Remember when Spurrier ran it up in Athens in 1995 by calling a reverse at the goal line for the TD that gave the Gators the finishing touches on a 52-17 beatdown? Do you remember Eric Kresser throwing a pair of touchdown passes in the fourth quarter when Georgia was already slapped silly? Remember Spurrier saying he wanted to be the first coach to hang "half a hundred" on Georgia in Sanford Stadium? 1968 had plenty to do with that. Coach Ellenson wasn't alive for Spurrier to call with congratulations but a call was made to Coach Graves to say "this one's for you."

3. THE PROBATION YEARS

Okay, we'll start with the obvious. Florida got nailed by the NCAA not just once, but twice. The first time, the Gators were hit with 109 violations, some of them as heinous as Dale Dorminey going back to Pensacola with a T-shirt and Hoss Adams buying him a pack of Juicy Fruit and a Sprite while waiting on the plane at the Gainesville airport. Hanging offenses! Some violations were pretty bad, but the majority were of the nickel and dime variety and for that Charley Pell was fired and the SEC championship the 1984 Gators won on the field was forfeited. The NCAA, in its infinite wisdom, gave the Gators two years probation without television and a maximum of 12 in consecutive recruiting classes. At the same time, Florida State, Tennessee, Auburn and Georgia all got slaps on the wrist for their NCAA violations. The NCAA was well aware that

Georgia had bent or broken every rule in the book to sign Herschel Walker, but that was overlooked and Georgia lost two scholarships, a small price to pay for one of the two or three greatest college football players of all time. When all this went down, Vince Dooley was chairman of the NCAA television committee. Coincidence that Georgia got off so lightly?

Georgia fans insist Vince Dooley was a man of the highest possible integrity, which doesn't exactly explain how it is that Georgia went on football probation three times (1965, 1978, 1982) while he was the coach and again in 1997 while he was the AD. He's the guy who hired Hugh Durham and Jim Harrick, who both put Georgia basketball in the NCAA jailhouse.

Dooley is also the same guy who allowed serious academic fraud scandal to go on right under his nose. Google Jan Kemp sometime. She was fired as Georgia's academic advisor because she wouldn't give athletes passing grades. She sued and won a $1.08 million settlement, an impressive amount in the 1990s.

Dooley was also front and center in the vote to strip the Gators of the 1984 SEC title. By the way, in 1984 the Gators skunked Georgia 27-0.

Years ago, I did a magazine article with College Football Hall of Famer and Gator great Wilber Marshall. When we got around to the subject of recruiting Wilber said, "I went to Florida because it was close to home and I'm a mama's boy. I didn't go there because they paid me to go but other schools made offers – some big offers – some of the same teams that voted to strip the SEC championship from us in 1984. You would go on recruiting trips and some fat cat booster would let you know what you could expect. That was pretty common then."

I asked if Georgia was complicit. Wilber laughed rather sarcastically.

The second probation resulted in the NCAA putting Spurrier's first Florida team on probation, so no bowl game. The SEC athletic directors, lobbied very hard by Vince Dooley, voted to make Florida ineligible for the SEC championship even though the Gators had the best record in the league. All that for something that happened in the Galen Hall years. Not a single player on that 1990 Florida roster was even on the team when Hall allegedly paid the child support for Jarvis Williams. Galen

denied he did it but people in Palatka swear the cash was paid back the next morning by Jarvis Williams' mother. None of that was ever substantiated and the NCAA never volunteered proof that it actually happened.

For that alleged crime, Galen was fired during the 1989 season. Florida AD Bill Arnsparger refused to fight the allegations but was very quick to fire Galen. Arnsparger saw this as the perfect opportunity to hire Mike Archer, who had succeeded him as the HBC at LSU. He would have done it if not for powerful Florida boosters like Ben Hill Griffin, who put him in his place.

Punishment should always fit the crime. It could be argued that what Florida did in 1984 deserved time in the NCAA jailhouse, but if that's the case, why was Florida's punishment so tough and the punishment to FSU (a couple of scholarships lost), Tennessee (something similar) and Georgia nothing more than a pop on the fanny and the NCAA saying "be good boys and don't do this again"?

Why also was it so important for Vince Dooley to go to the mat to have the Gators stripped of the 1984 SEC title and then prevent the 1990 team from winning it? Mr. Integrity got slapped with NCAA violations back in 1966 and 1968. His SEC titles were never stripped. After all, this is the same Vince Dooley whose history of cheating dated back to 1965.

THE 2007 STORM THE FIELD INCIDENT

Immediately following a 1-yard run by Knowshon Moreno that gave Georgia the lead with six minutes to go in the first quarter, some 70 Georgia players left the bench and stormed the field, taunting the Gators and doing their best to draw a reaction that would have resulted in offsetting penalties. To their credit, the Gators did not retaliate but that incident changed the entire tenor of the game, which Georgia eventually won, 42-30.

In the aftermath, Mark Richt claimed complete surprise and innocence. If so, then why didn't he or even one of his assistant coaches try to stop the players, knowing it would force Georgia to kick off from the 20? It was all planned in advance despite Richt's denials.

At SEC Media Days in Birmingham in the summer of 2008, Richt offered the same lame excuse. He was lying. I wrote that his nose had grown, which set off a firestorm on radio row. When I was a guest on Rachel Barribeau's show out of Columbus, I understand the Georgia supporters blew out the switchboard.

Meyer showed Georgia storming the field on a constant reel in the Florida locker room for an entire year. When Georgia took the ball first in 2008, a Matt Stafford to Moreno pass lost three yards on the first play. On second down, Moreno had a close encounter with Mr. Spikes, who decleated him. Florida played like its hair was on fire. In the fourth quarter after Georgia had finally scored a TD, Chris Rainey took the kickoff and stood in place wiggling his hips before taking off. He was mocking Georgia. With 44 seconds remaining and Florida ahead 49-10, Meyer called a time out. He called another one after the next play. Both times the CBS cameras caught Richt looking up at the scoreboard.

It was payback for a low level stunt and it was righteous.

THE 21-YEAR REVERSAL OF FORTUNE AND THE 15 YEARS SINCE

Spurrier changed everything and tilted the rivalry advantages strongly in Florida's favor. The Head Ball Coach understood the hypocrisy and he knew the history. That has everything to do with why he took such delight in sticking it to Georgia (11 wins in 12 years; average margin of victory 23.36 points) every chance he got. Ron Zook beat Georgia two-out-of-three and might have made it three-for-three if he hadn't been fired the Monday prior to the 2004 Georgia game. He still almost won that one. As a Spurrier assistant for five years (1991-95) Zook was well versed in what beating Georgia meant and why it was so important. Urban Meyer wasn't around for the Spurrier years but he understood it too. He beat Georgia five times in six seasons. He knew all about the recruiting advantages for beating Georgia and he had been well versed in the history of the rivalry.

In the years since Urban Meyer left Florida in 2010, the Florida-Georgia rivalry has tilted heavily in Georgia's favor. Florida has won only four times, the last one in 2020. Georgia has won the last five and is an 11.5-

point favorite to beat the Gators this year when the game is being played in Atlanta due to stadium renovations in Jacksonville.

Since Meyer resigned after the 2010 season, the Gators are now on their fifth head coach. One reason Georgia is on such a roll is because it has had only two football coaches since 2001 – Mark Richt (2001-15) and Kirby Smart since 2016. Continuity and good coaches have given Georgia a huge advantage that first year Florida coach Jon Sumrall will have to chip away.

Sumrall respects what Georgia has done, particularly the last 11 years when Smart has won four SEC and two national championships. While respecting that Georgia's success can't be undone, he pals around with Spurrier and Meyer. Bet all that is sacred that the two of them have filled him in on all the details.

If Georgia doesn't make him seethe already, it won't take long for Jon Sumrall to fully understand it is dutiful for Florida football coaches to revile the Georgia Bulldogs. If he doesn't already, he will learn to despise them.

It is the duty of every single Gator.

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Oklahoma at Florida

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